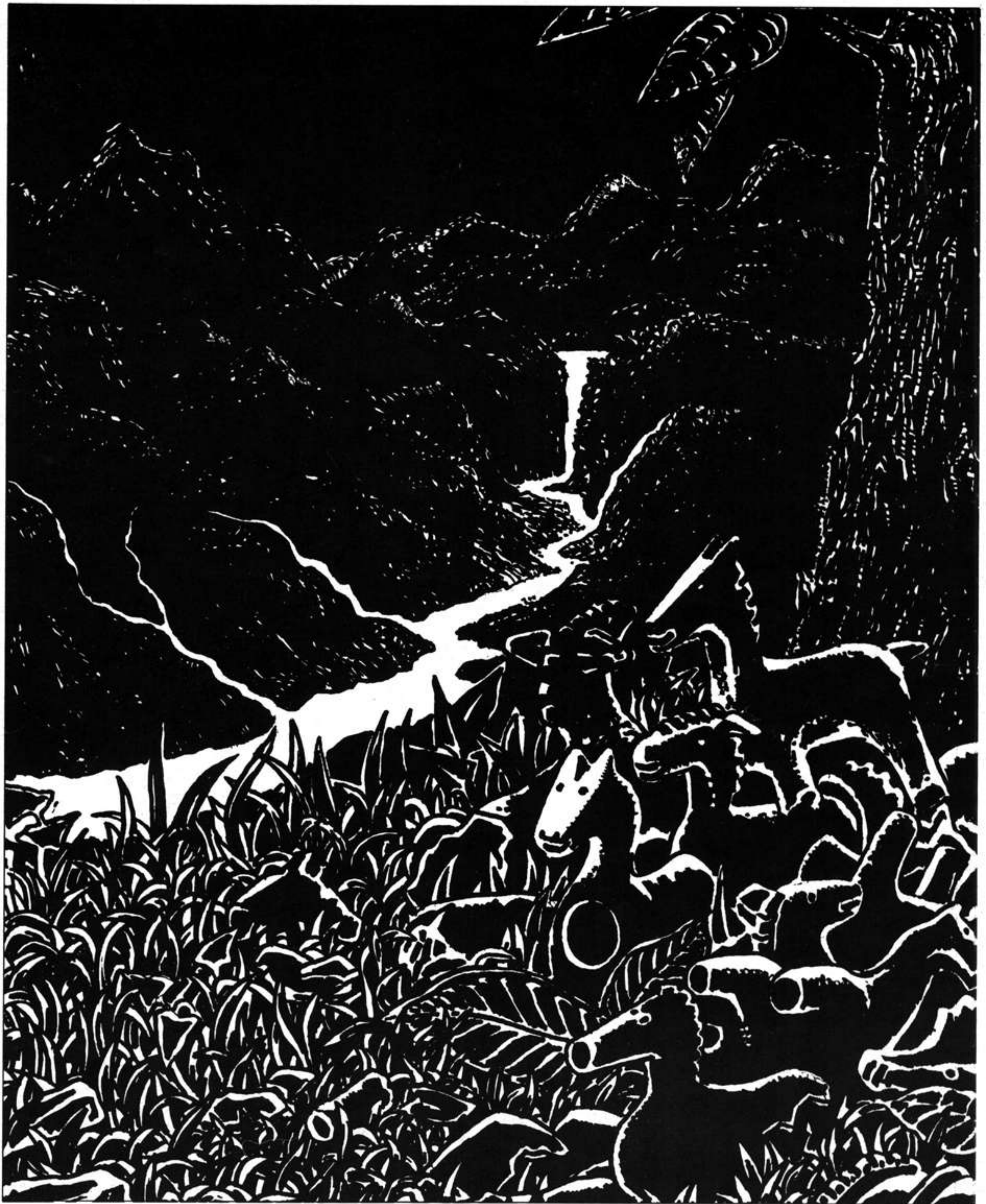
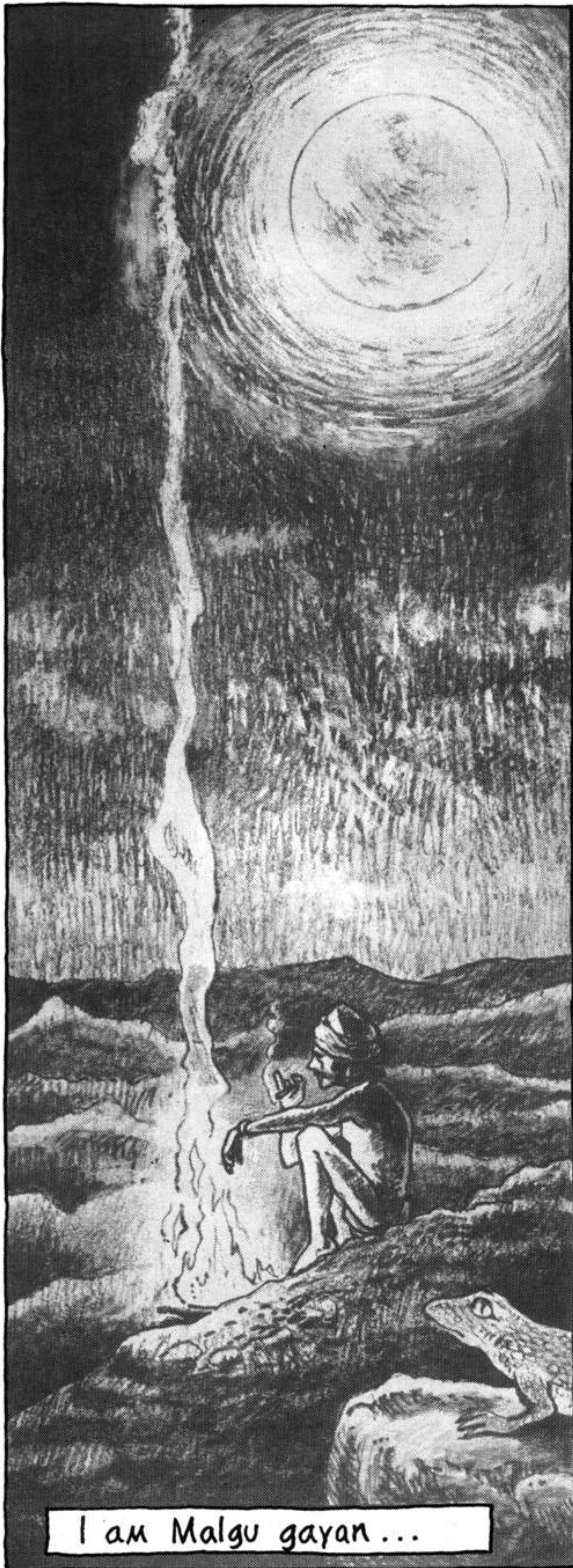




Part I : THE SPRING

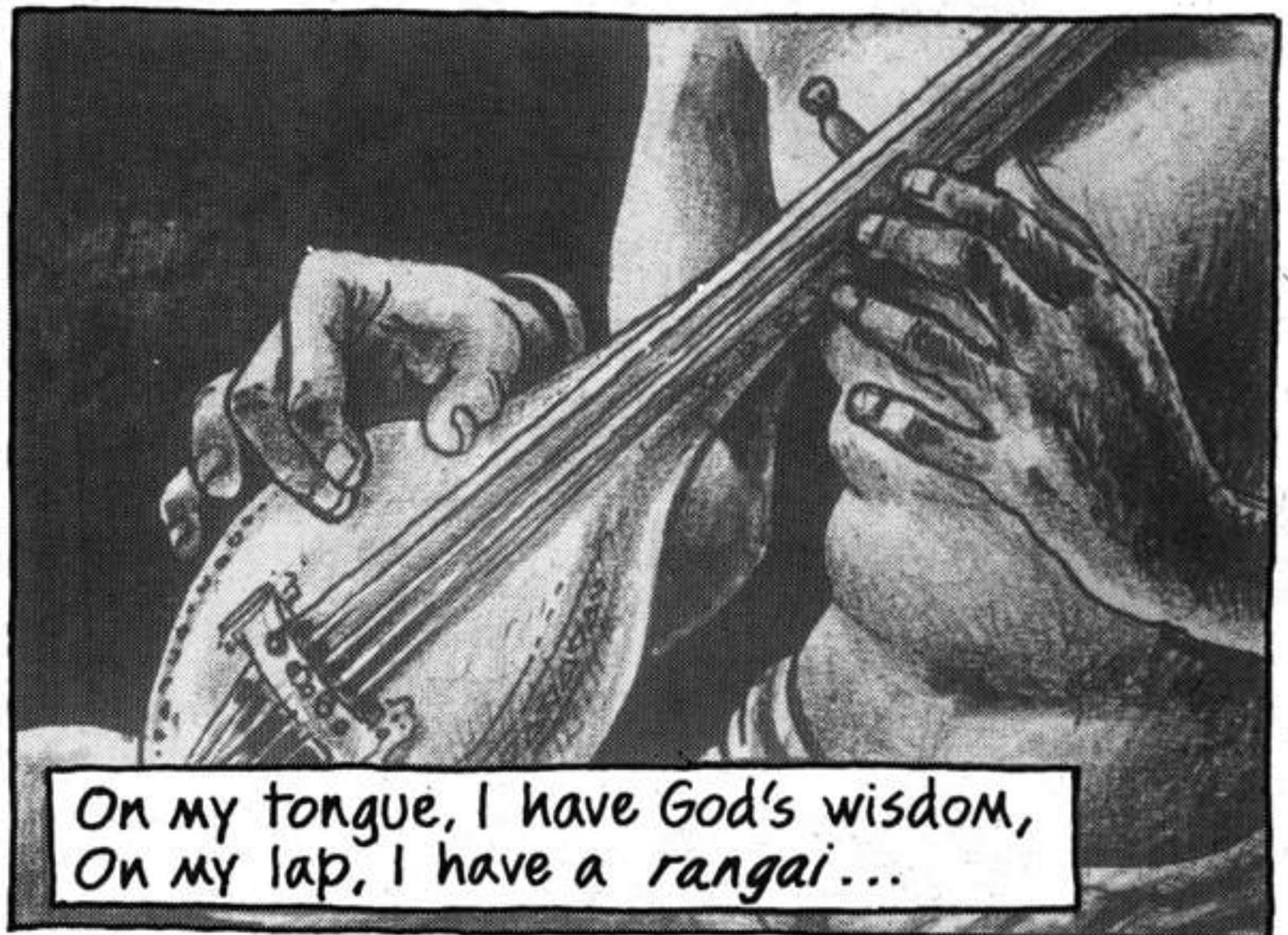
KUJUM CHANTU



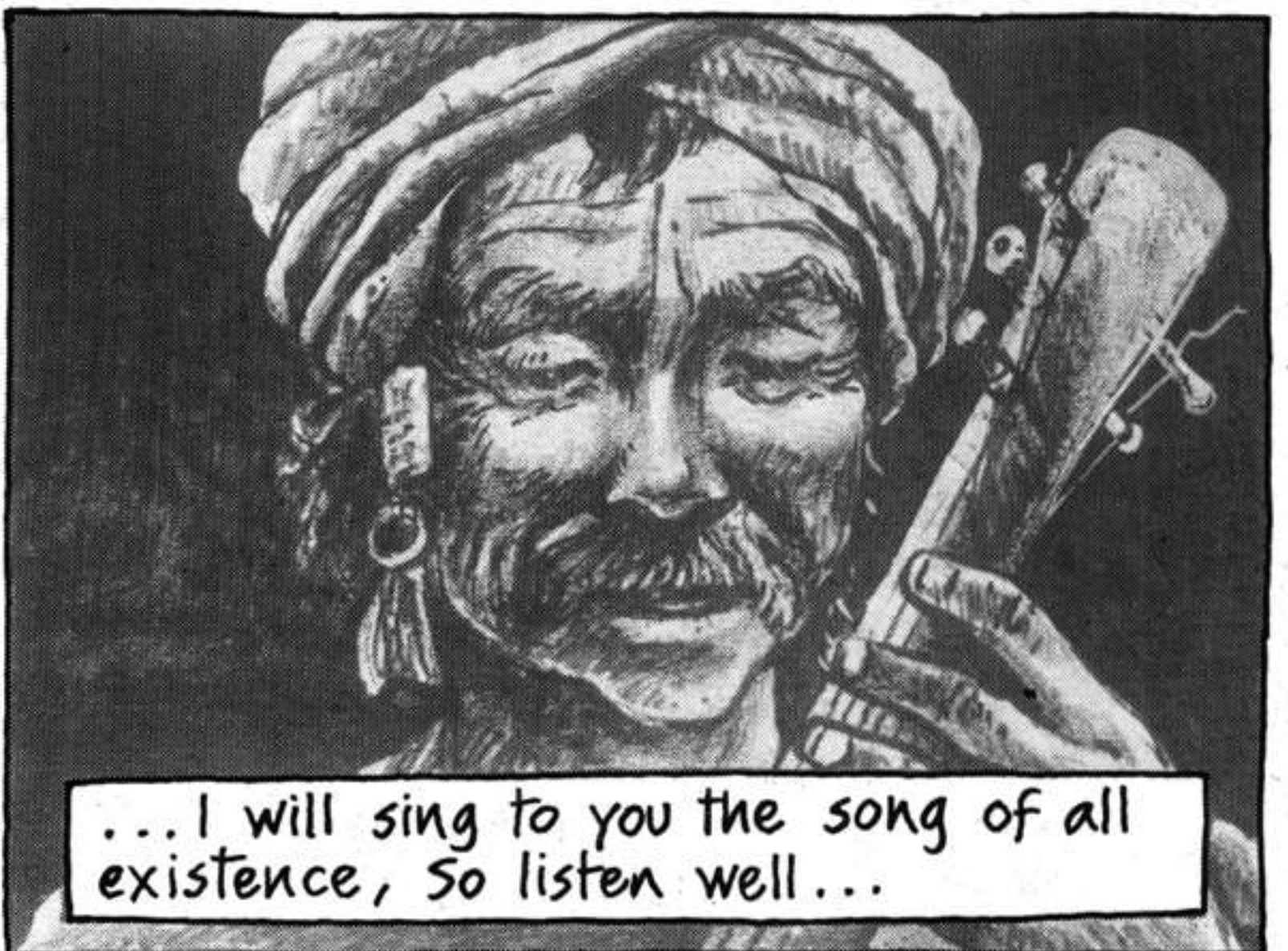
I am Malgu gayan ...



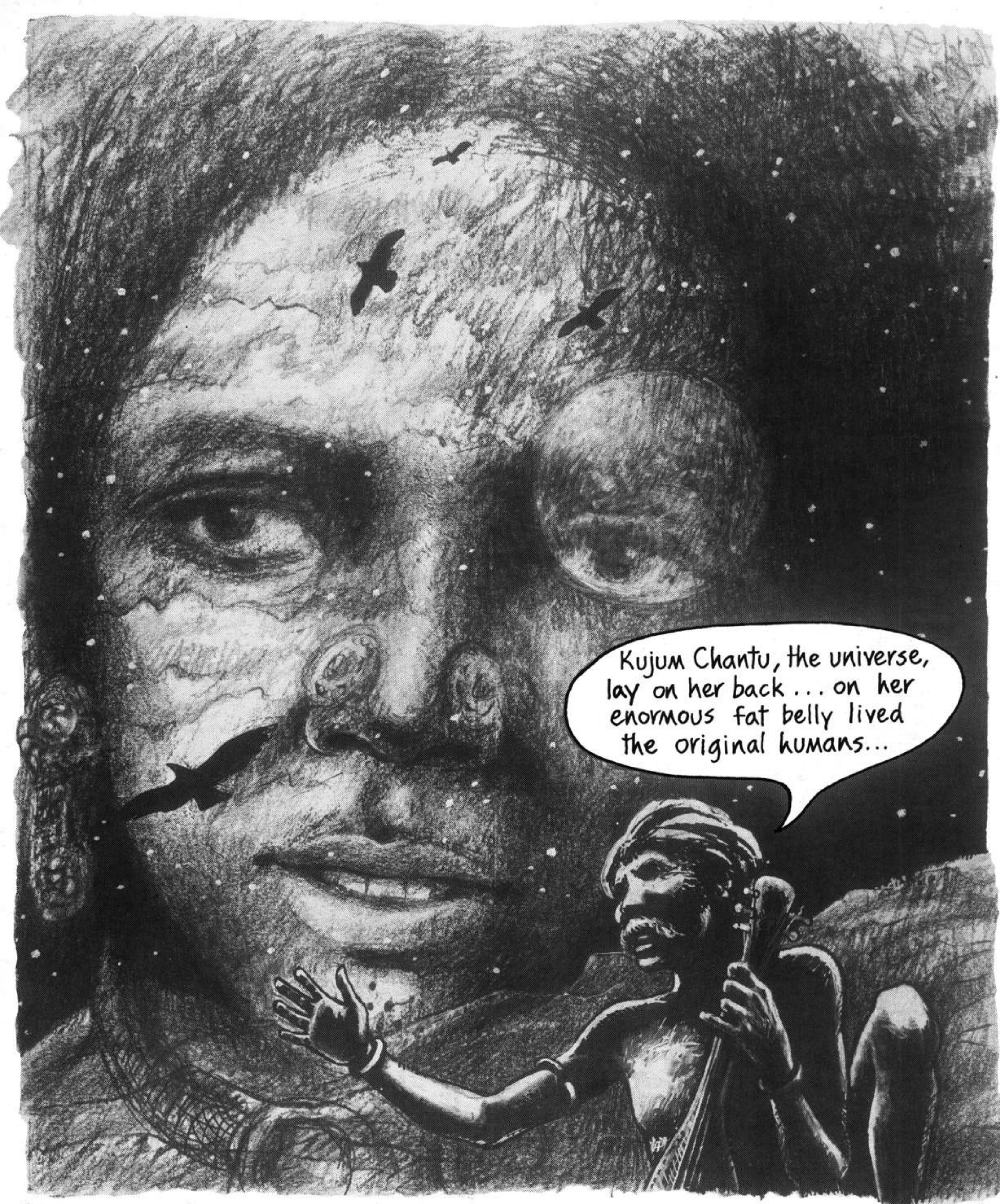
... God give me wisdom...



On my tongue, I have God's wisdom,
On my lap, I have a rangai...



... I will sing to you the song of all
existence, So listen well...



Kujum Chantu, the universe,
lay on her back ... on her
enormous fat belly lived
the original humans...

..One day, it occurred to Kujum Chantu that if she ever got up and walked about, everyone would fall off and be killed.



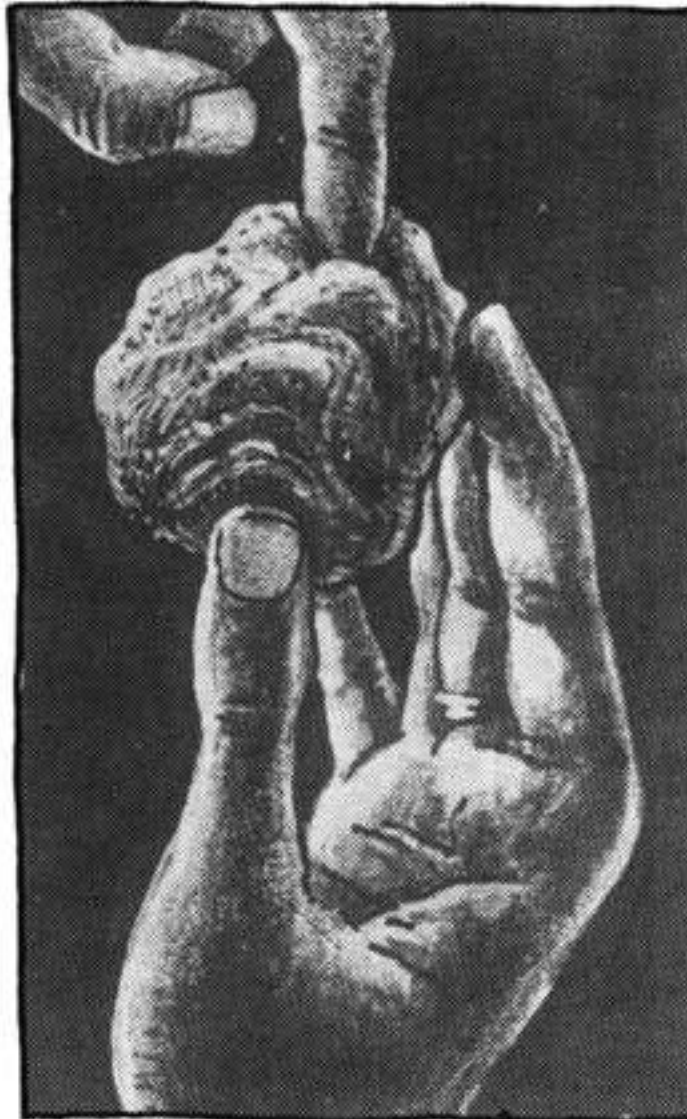
She decided to make a world for humans to live on...



..rubbed some dirt off her chest and shaped it. Kneaded it, squeezed it, and patted it...



...Made a world full of pits and holes, projections and distortions...



Smooth in some places, rough in others, and held it in the palm of her hand, well pleased...



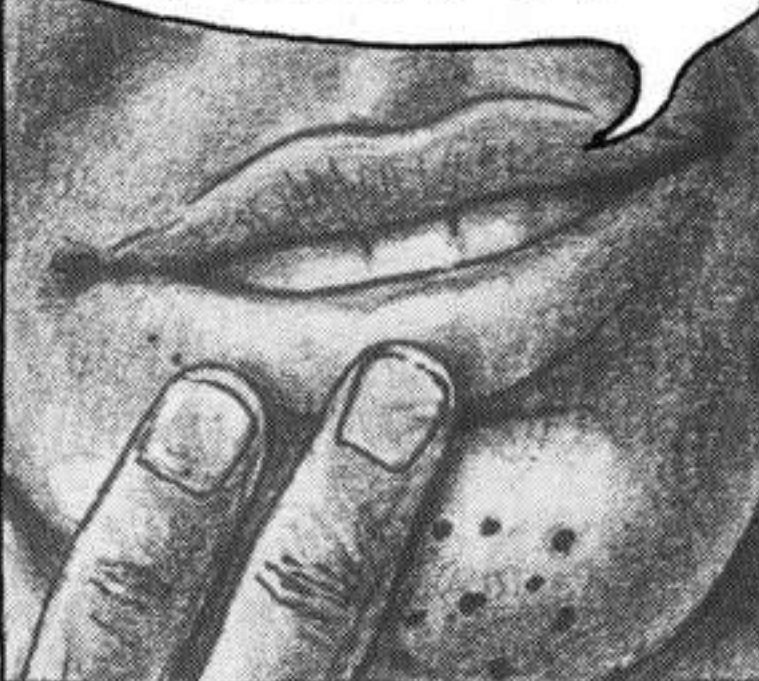
I have made the world, but it's barren. How shall I give it life?



So she made trees, shrubs and grasses and planted them!



Beautiful looks my world. But what shall be the creatures to inhabit it?



She took some clay and started shaping...shaped some lizards. Made some tigers and bears. Made snakes and birds..



...All kinds of creatures she shaped. To put blood into all of them, she planted a garden....



..Part of this garden was for us humans. This was the garden of *juvar*. She gave breasts to the *juvar*. This is why if we don't eat *juvar*, our blood dries up. For livestock, there was the garden of *jinjivi* grass. She gave it breasts too. So the livestock also came to have blood.

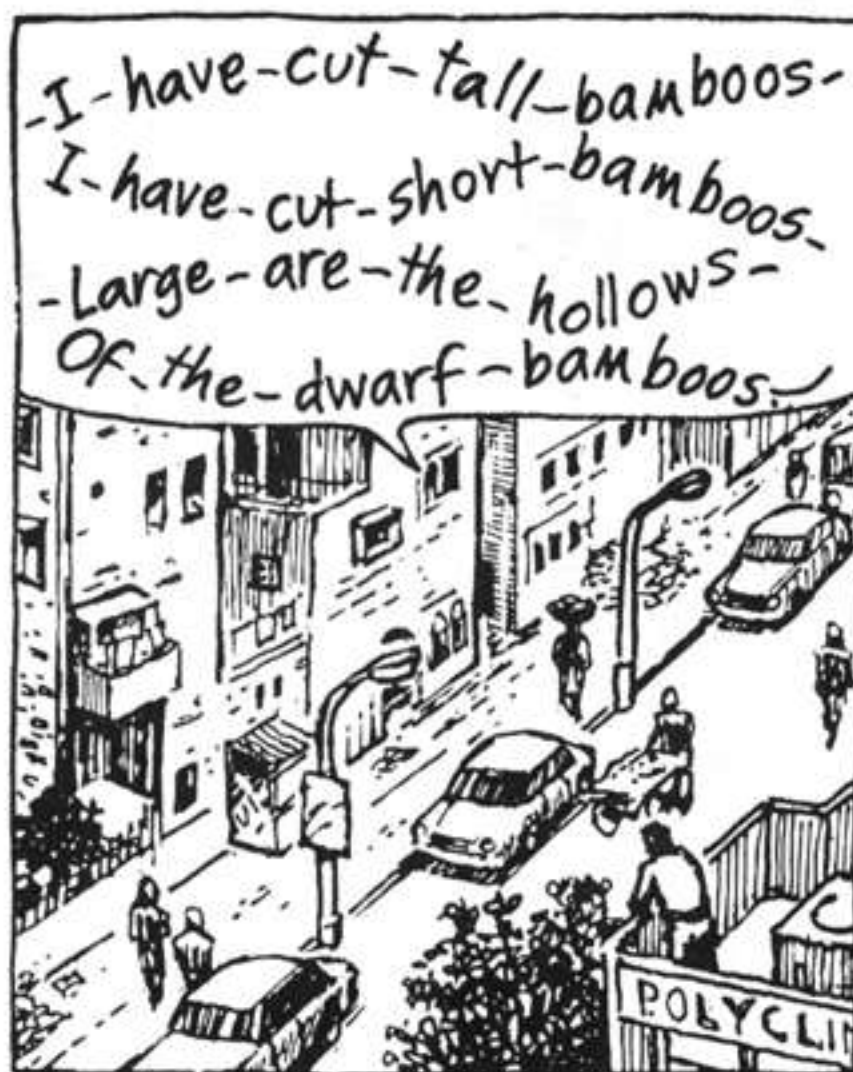


For lizards, there was the brown-coloured *bengali-phool*. For snakes, the *ninghal* tree with its poisonous flowers of blue and yellow...



And so, the entire world, with all its creatures, with enough food in it for all, she created.

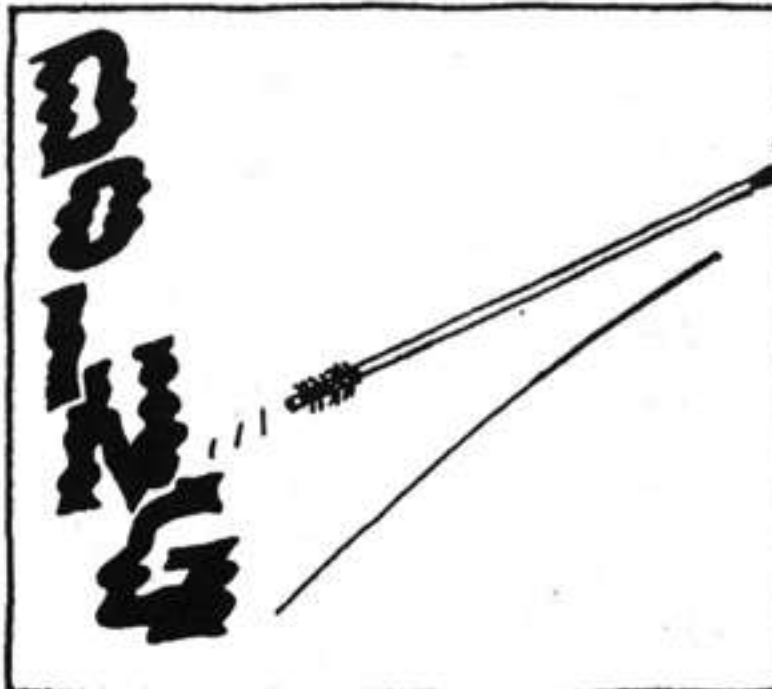
RELKU'S STORY



I was born in a village called Jamli. You've heard of a place called Ballanpur, no? My village is only three hours by bus from there, by the Rewa river.

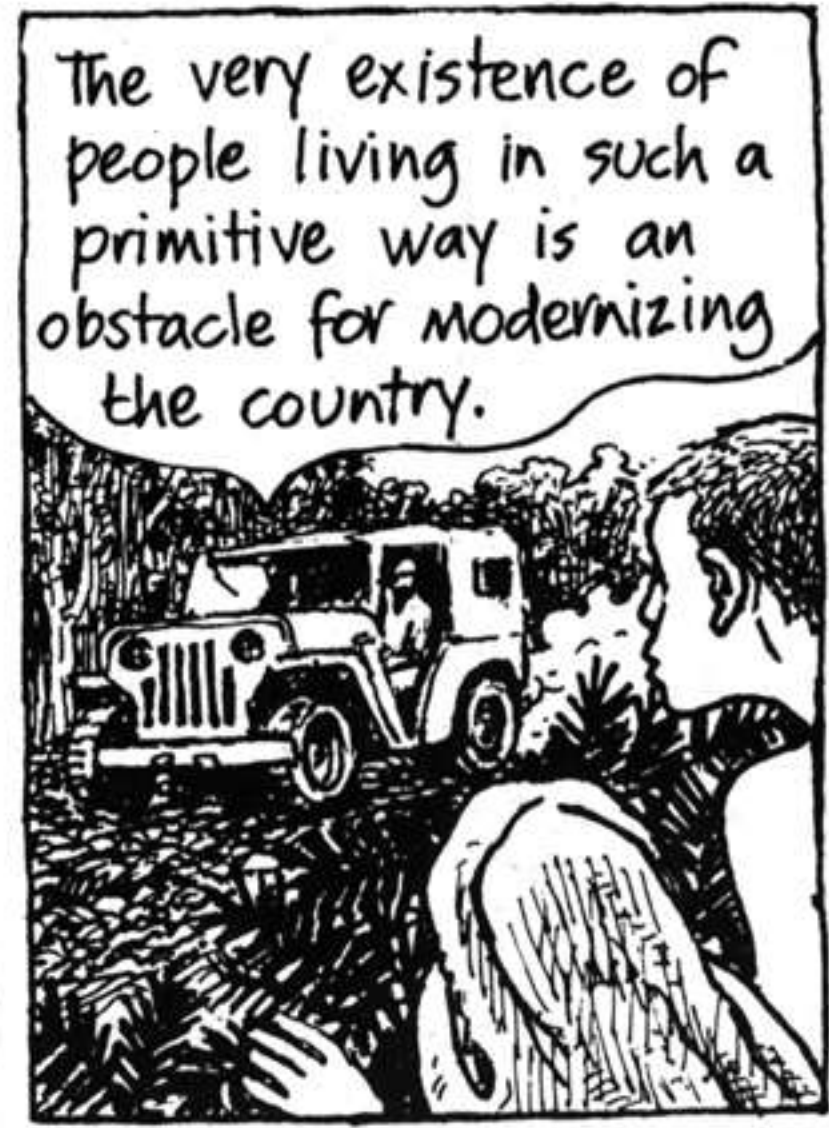
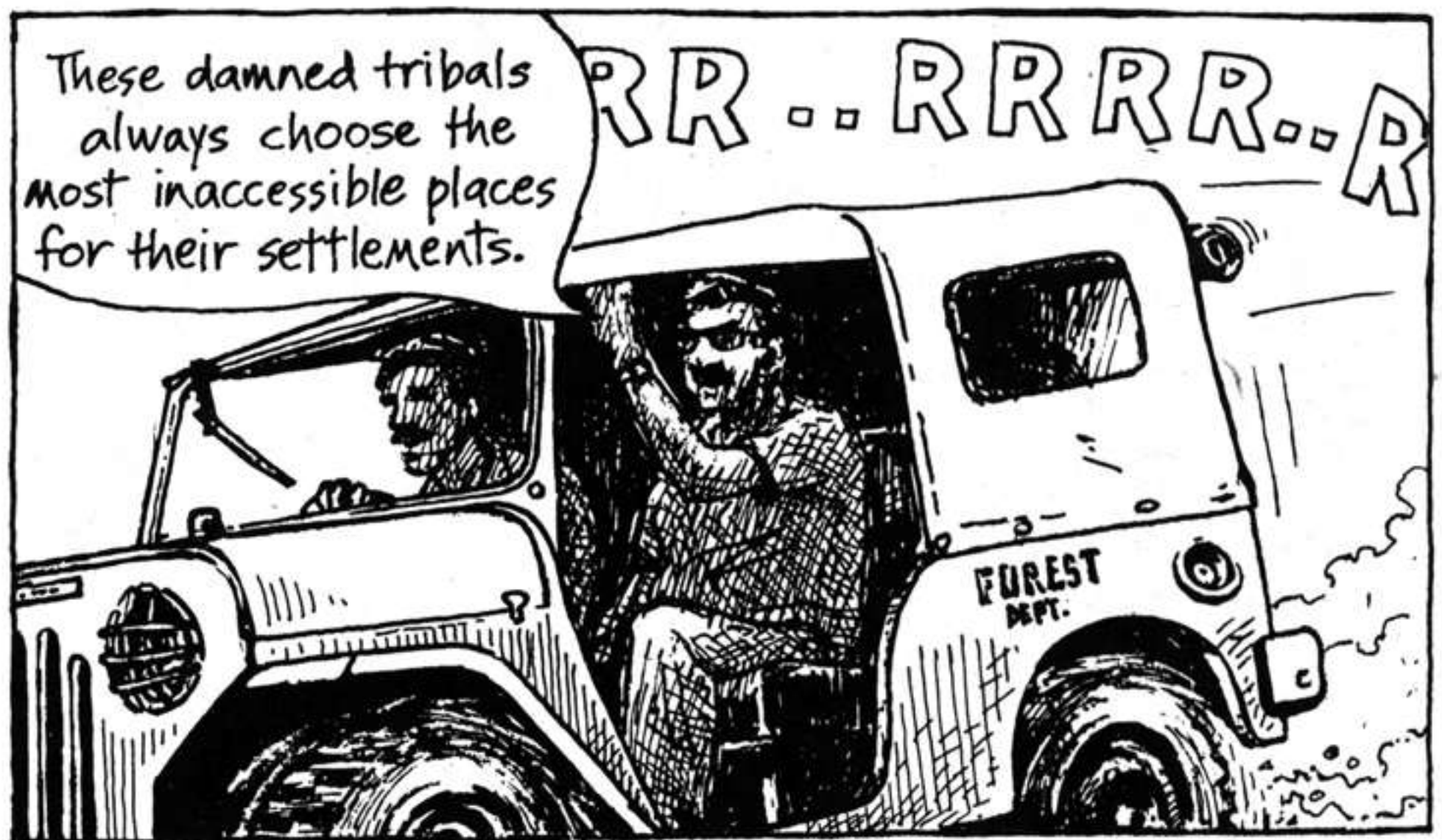
I still remember how, as children, we used to swing from the banyan trees!

Look, Somariyo, we've almost filled this basket with mahua flowers already!



RRR..RR.RRRRR





... I am told that despite repeated warnings, you people have been cultivating land, grazing your cattle, taking wood and hunting on forest land which belongs to the sarkar.



As you must be well aware, the government declared this area a reserve forest several years ago. That means it belongs to the forest department.



And whoever uses it in any way without permission will be punished!



Sahib, These hills and forests are our home! We were all born here - our ancestors have lived here and after us our children.....



No! The time has come for all this nonsense to stop. You people have to give up thinking of the forests as your private property to use as you please



I don't understand this. What has this got to do with the sarkar? And how is it possible to live without farming or hunting?



Sahib, This land is our mata. She gives us food and shelter. She takes care of our needs. We worship the trees, the river, the hills....



Now listen! No one expects you to live without food. But you must realize that times have changed. You can't go on living the way your ancestors used to.



The sarkar is trying to do a lot of development work in this area. All of you can benefit from these schemes, provided you learn to cooperate!



Already work on the pucca road from Ballanpur to Mathwa has started. It will pass through here...

... That means there will be proper means of transport available... so that, little by little, these jungles can be opened up. Proper houses, even factories can be built. Do you even understand what all this means?

Yes, sahib.

Yes.

Yes, sahib.

Really? Then don't just sit there like a bunch of idiots, nodding your heads. Tell me what it will mean!

Does it mean we'll have to go away from here and live somewhere else?

No, you fool! What it means is that perhaps your son will get an education and acquire some intelligence!

And then, maybe he can get a job and earn money instead of spending his life wandering around the jungles like a monkey!

Ho
Ho
Ho!

You there! Maybe you can begin by learning to put on clothes like the rest of us!



We had to give gifts to the *nakedar* and other officers, or kill chickens when they came to the house - only then would they allow us to graze our cattle, collect grass for making rope...



While the *theke*dars, who had all sorts of papers and permits, were allowed to bring their labourers to cut down as many trees as they wished, to take away to the city.



The forest guards were very friendly with them, and they would come and go together in their *moters*.



After some years, they completed the road that the *rangersaab* had told us about...

It was like a big snake, from whose belly emerged the caravans and *moters* of traders from the bazar.

Earlier, no *bazaria* would have come into our forest even by mistake. But the road changed that...

They started by setting up small shops and businesses near the road...



Slowly, they began to take over our land, sometimes even by force...



Oh, it was sad to see... so many lost their homes at that time. We did not know that our turn would also come soon.



I see... but couldn't you people have gone to the police, or were they also a part of it?



The basic problem, rangersaab, in developing the Jamli area, is the attitude of the adivasis there....



They have begun to get increasingly uncooperative and resentful of outsiders entering what they consider to be THEIR forest.



Just the other day, some of my men were roughed up by a gang of adivasis claiming that trees were being felled on village land.



Really? Did you lodge a police complaint?



No, Sharmaji, I let it pass... But you understand what I'm trying to say?



It's better to take some strong action now, before such ideas start to spread... You know? Show them who's the boss.



My boys were telling me that in Jamli village itself, a few of the men have been talking openly against the thekedars... some of the names mentioned were Antriyo Singh and Bhuriyo Vasava.



I see what you mean...
A crackdown on the
more vocal ones will serve
as an effective example
for the rest!



Don't worry, Aggarwal.
Your interests as
a forest contractor
will be taken care
of.



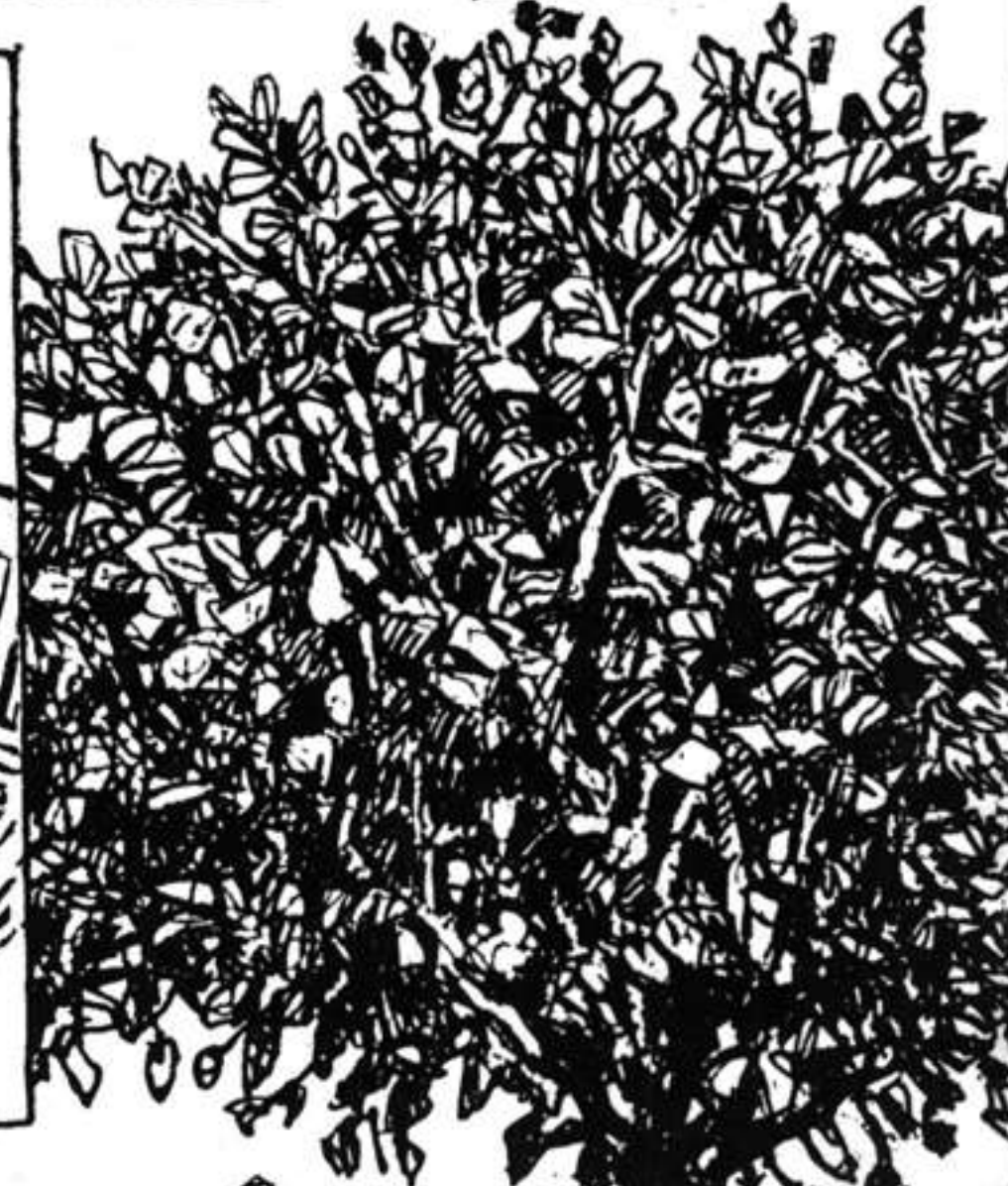
I'm meeting the
police inspector of
Jamli thana
tomorrow... I'll
have a word with
him.



Thank you, rangersaab!
The promptness and
efficiency with which you
handle such affairs has
made you something of a
legendary figure in these
parts!



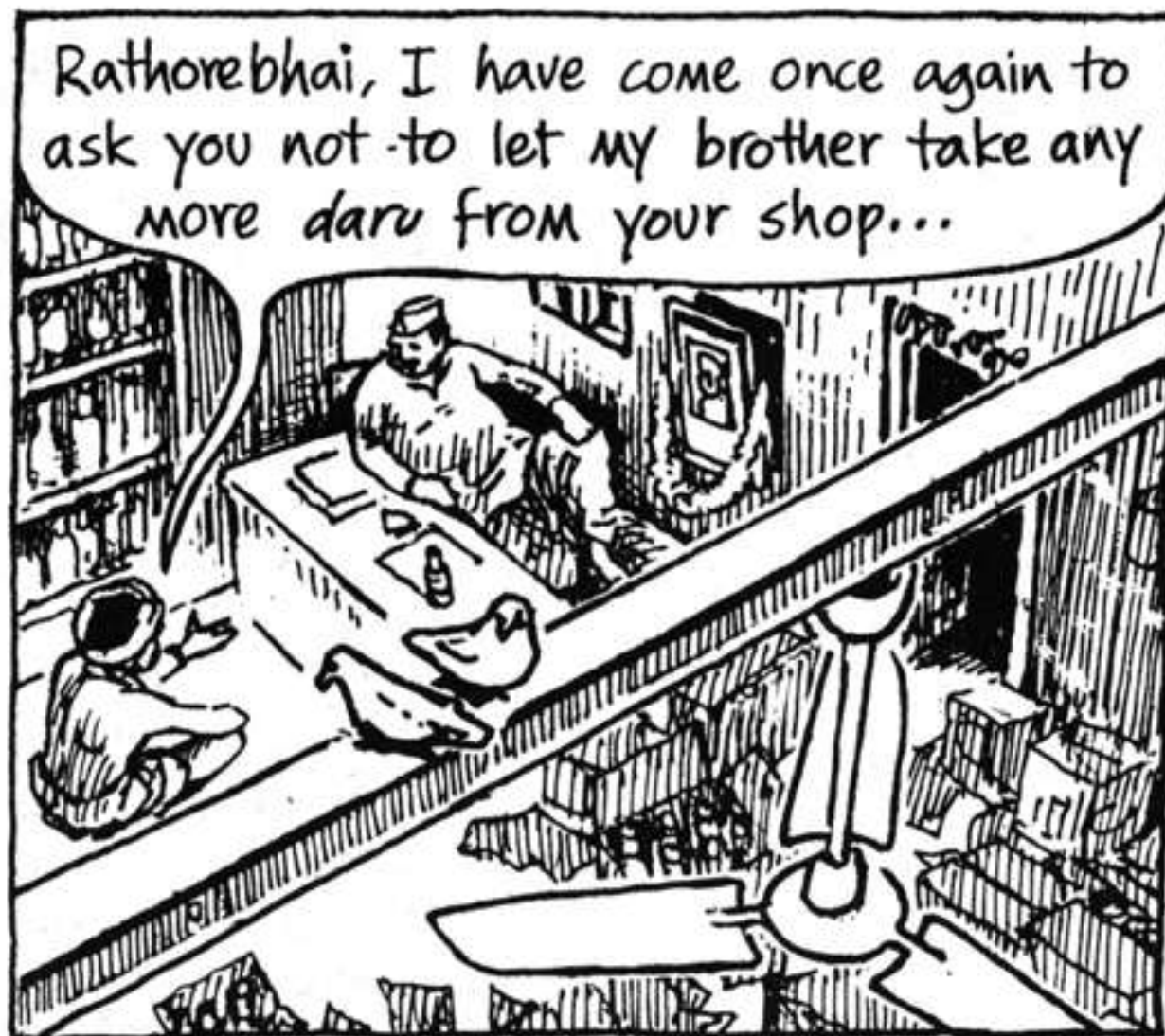
Come, come, there's no need for
this flattery. Helping these backward
people to improve themselves is not just
a duty for me, but a
personal mission.



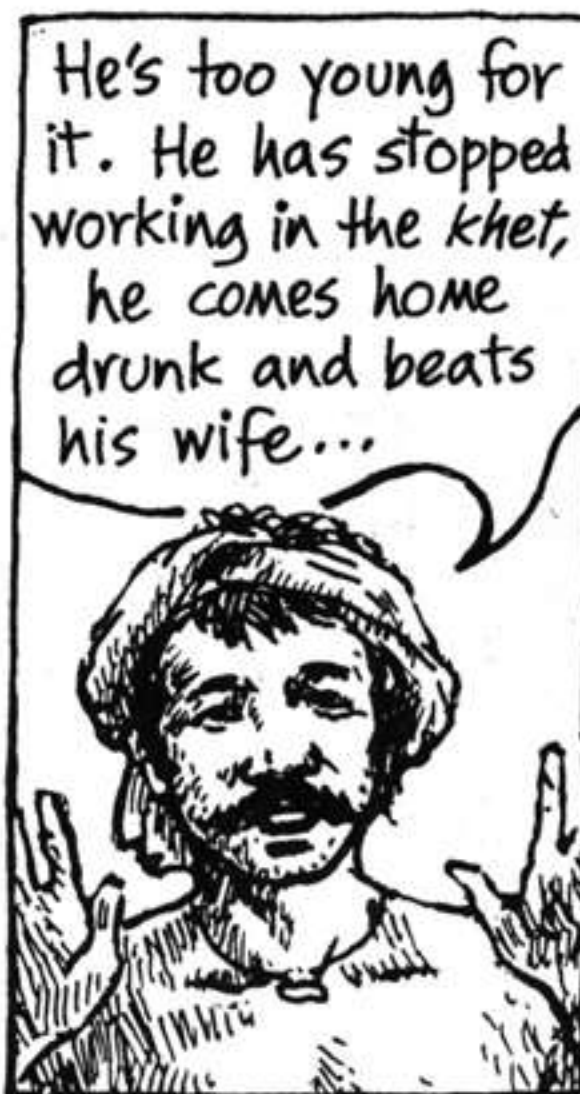
I will never know when and why
they decided to pick on us...
perhaps because my father refused
to be cowed by the thekedar and
his bullies.... Or perhaps because our
land was very good land, near
the river....



... And Rathore, the big liquor merchant
had his eye on it. It was he who got my
uncle Maaru addicted to Inglish by
encouraging him to take it on credit.



Rathorebhai, I have come once again to ask you not to let my brother take any more daru from your shop...



He's too young for it. He has stopped working in the khet, he comes home drunk and beats his wife...



We've reasoned with him - I've even hit him a couple of times, but it's no use.



Hmm...

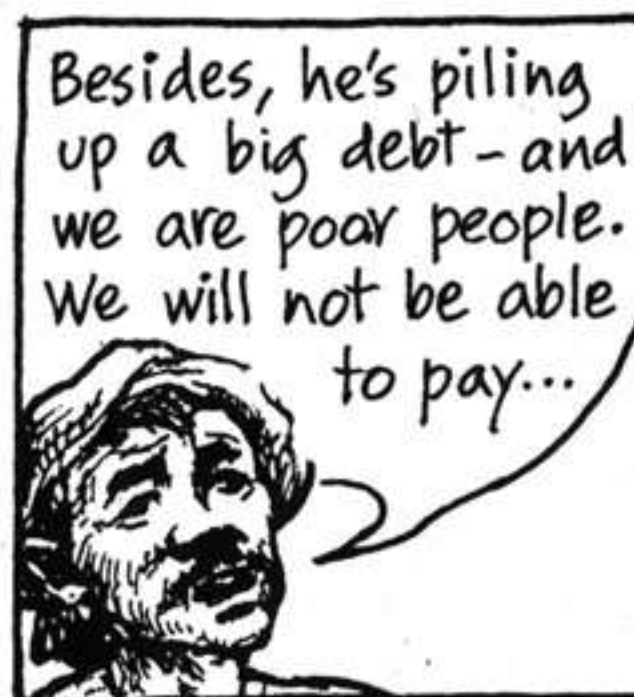


PTVI



Ha Ha Ha!

Listen, I'm not his mother-in-law. I'm not interested in what he does after drinking. So don't come here singing the same song again and again.



Besides, he's piling up a big debt - and we are poor people. We will not be able to pay...



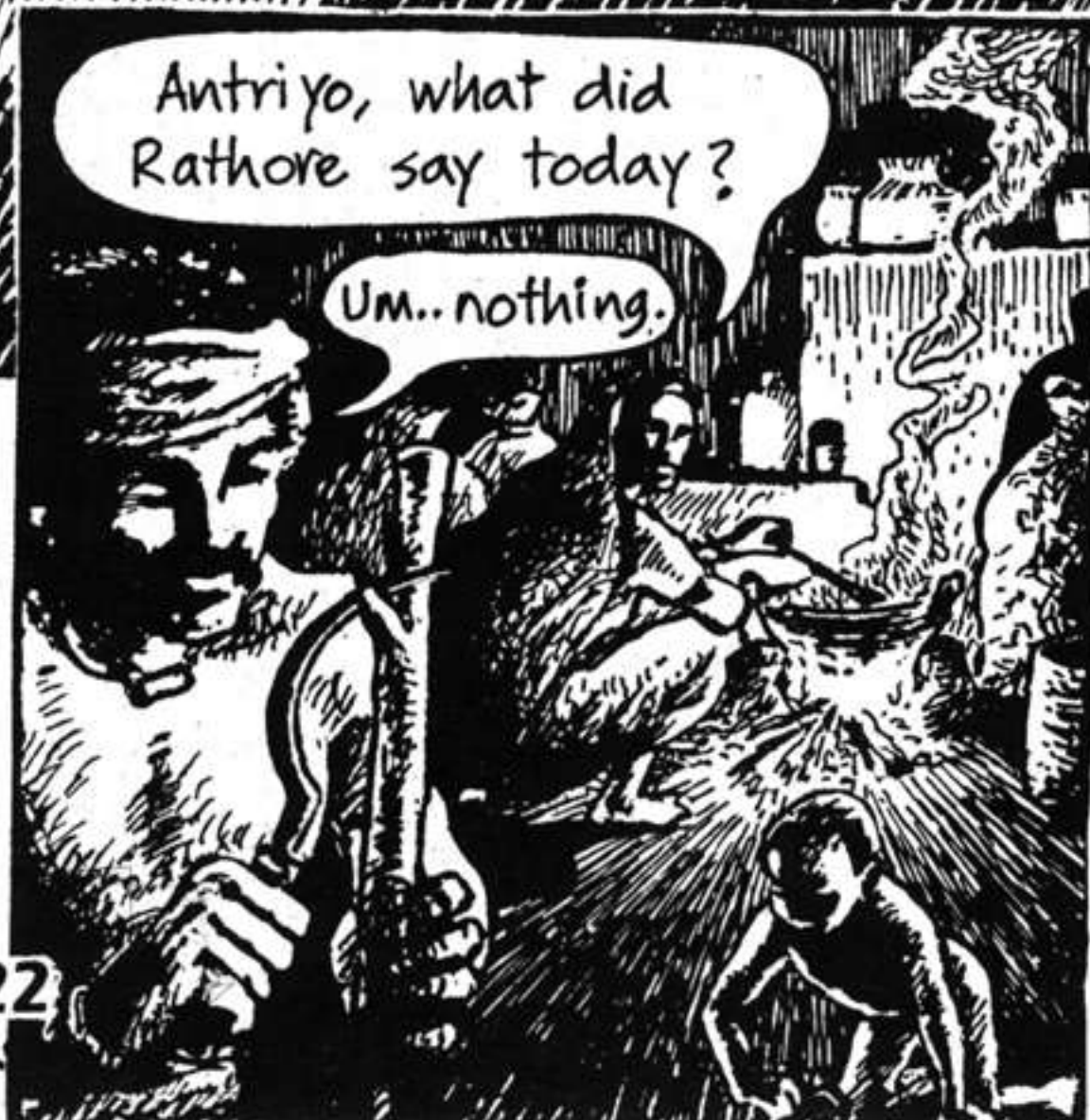
I said stop wasting my time!



Julati, looks like your husband is going to be late again.

Must be lying drunk in a ditch somewhere.

Hee Hee Hee! The rain will do him good!



Antriyo, what did Rathore say today?

Um.. nothing.

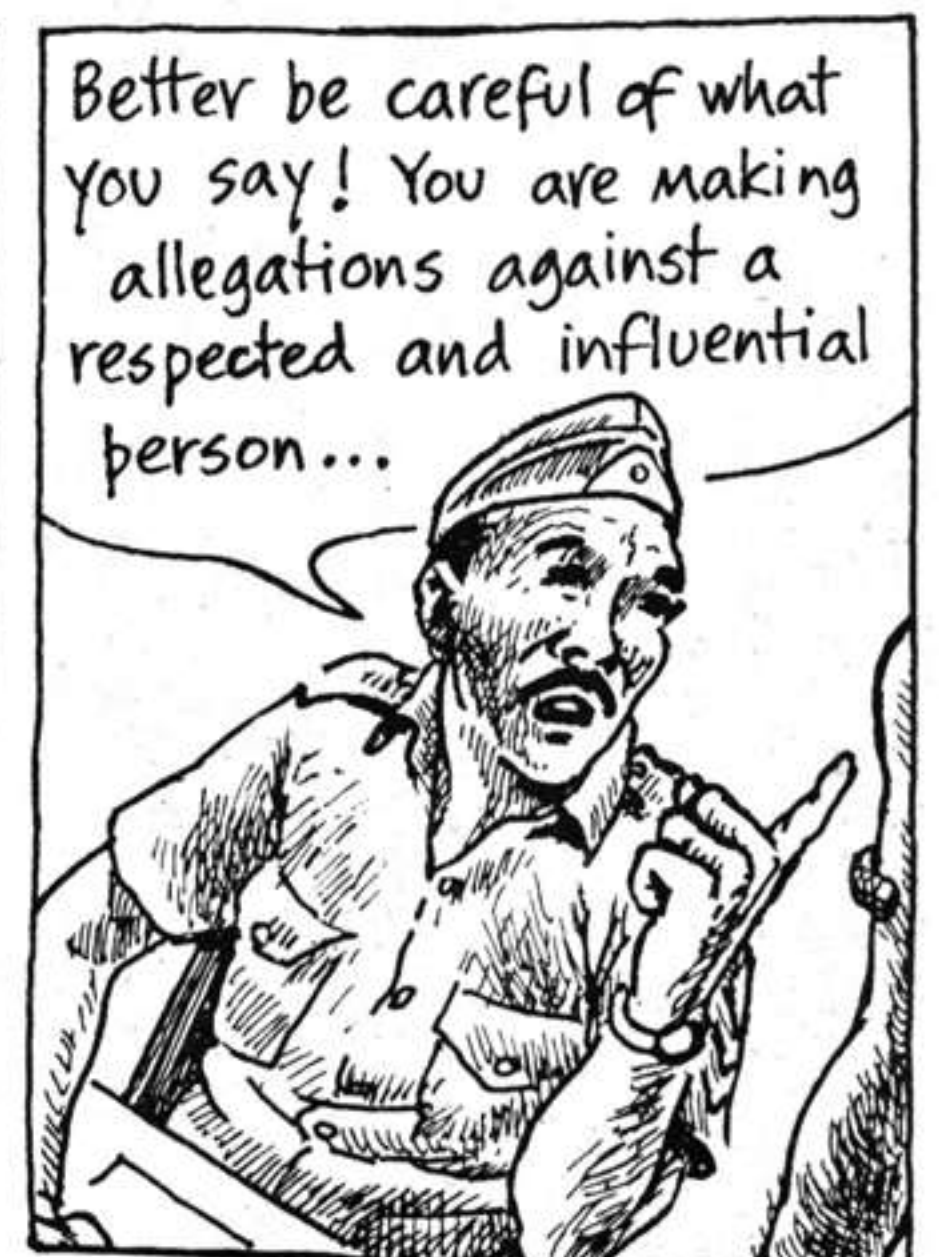
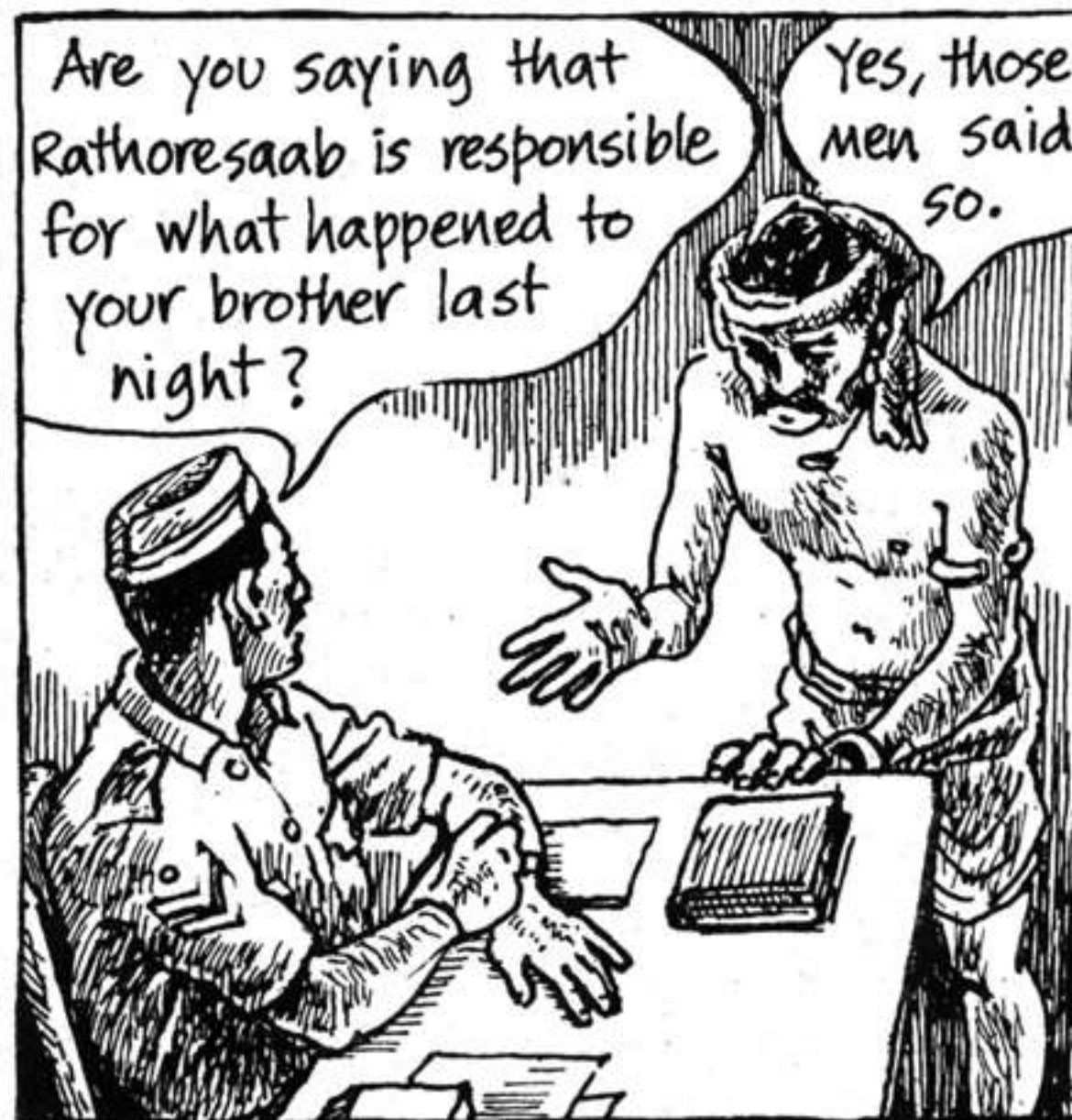


I don't understand why he gives Maaru that stuff on credit.

Hee Hee Hee!

Relku, stop giggling and go see why the dog is making a noise.

WOW
WOW



If, by chance, it turns out to be untrue, you're going to be in big trouble.

So think about it. Do you still want to make a complaint?

Yes.

I think the constable tried to warn my father about the consequences of trying to tackle Rathore, but my father felt that he had been dishonoured. And, for our people, that is an intolerable thing.

But why was the officer reluctant in noting down your complaint?

I don't know

Somariyo, Relku and Devla have already left with Budhyakaka to take Maaru to the big hospital in Ballanpur.



Hey woman! Is this where Antriyo lives?

Yes, I'm Antriyo... Have you come about my complaint?

Get in. You'll find out soon enough.



So, you're the one who's been making up stories about Rathoreji?



Now where did a jungli like you get the gall to come making complaints against civilized people?



But it's true!



UNN..H



SCUM! Falsely accusing Rathore saab in order to get out of paying your debts, hey?

WAIT!



THUNK

Ahh...



Okay, lock him up now.



That settles the matter then, Inspector saab.

Right.



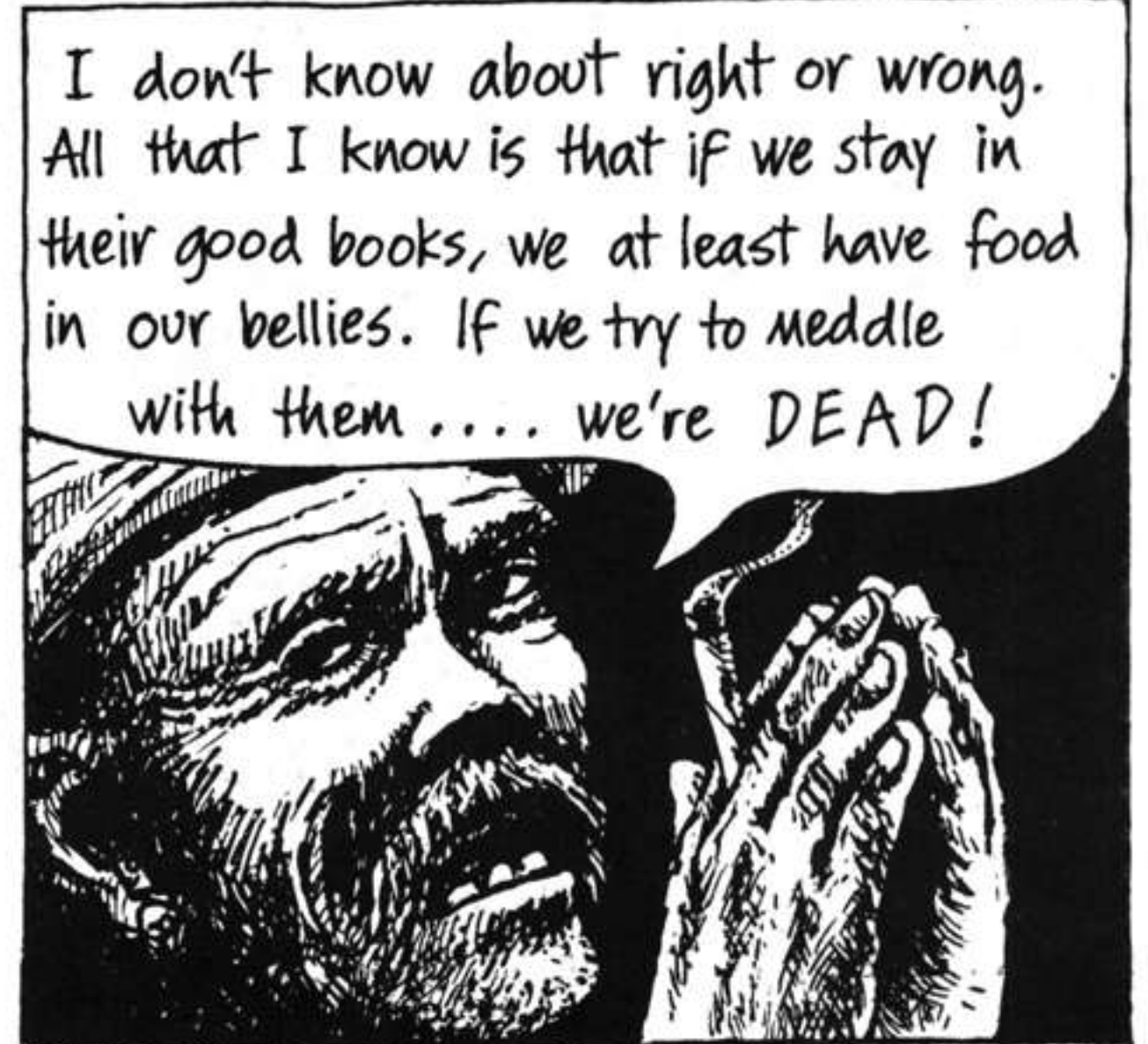
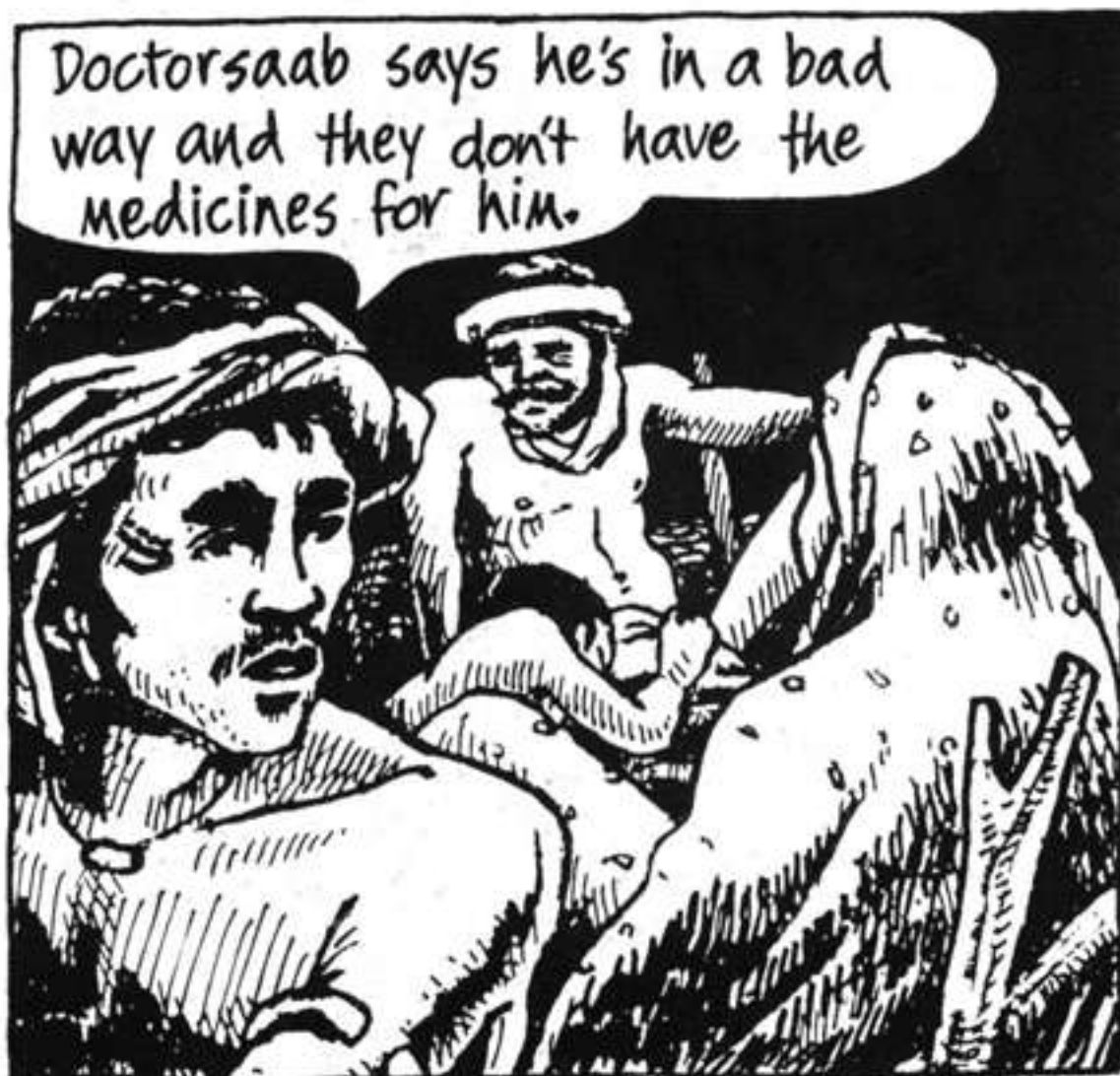
Er...if you could put in a word to the ACP, since you know him personally...

Of course!



Ha Ha Ha! What shall I tell him? That you did your job, as an officer of the law? Ha Ha!







No one knew how the fire started. The police made a report saying it was an accident.



The whole village knew it was done by Rathore, but there was no proof. Then uncle Maaru died in hospital...



... And we were forced to give away all our land in payment for uncle's debts.



Strange, isn't it? You've been working here for years, but I'd never have known that you've been through so much.



But tell me... Maaru's debt couldn't have been THAT big!



It was Rathore's word against ours. And he showed his accounts to the *adhikaris*.



I will never forget that time, Vishnubhai. One day, we were happy cultivating our own land...



... living in a house my father and uncles had built with their own hands



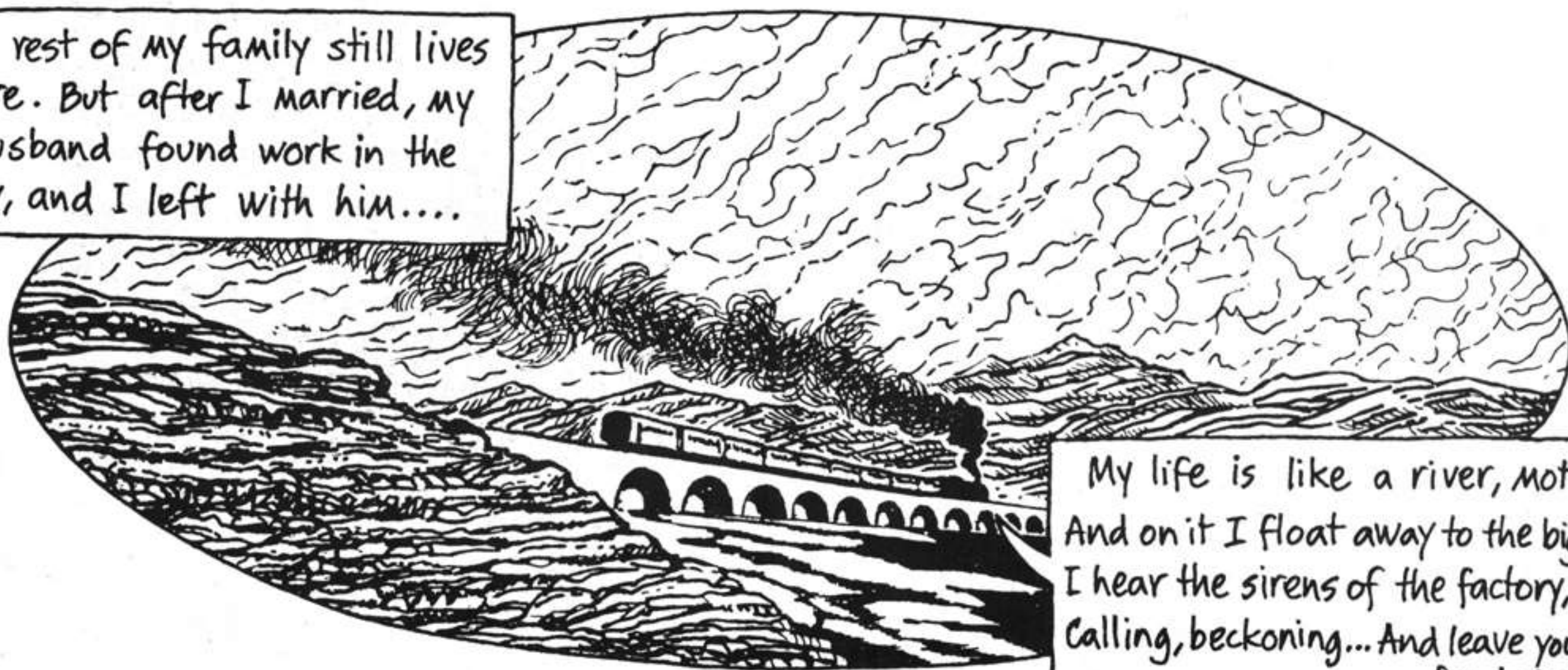
And the next day we were on the way to Ballanpur to work as landless labourers



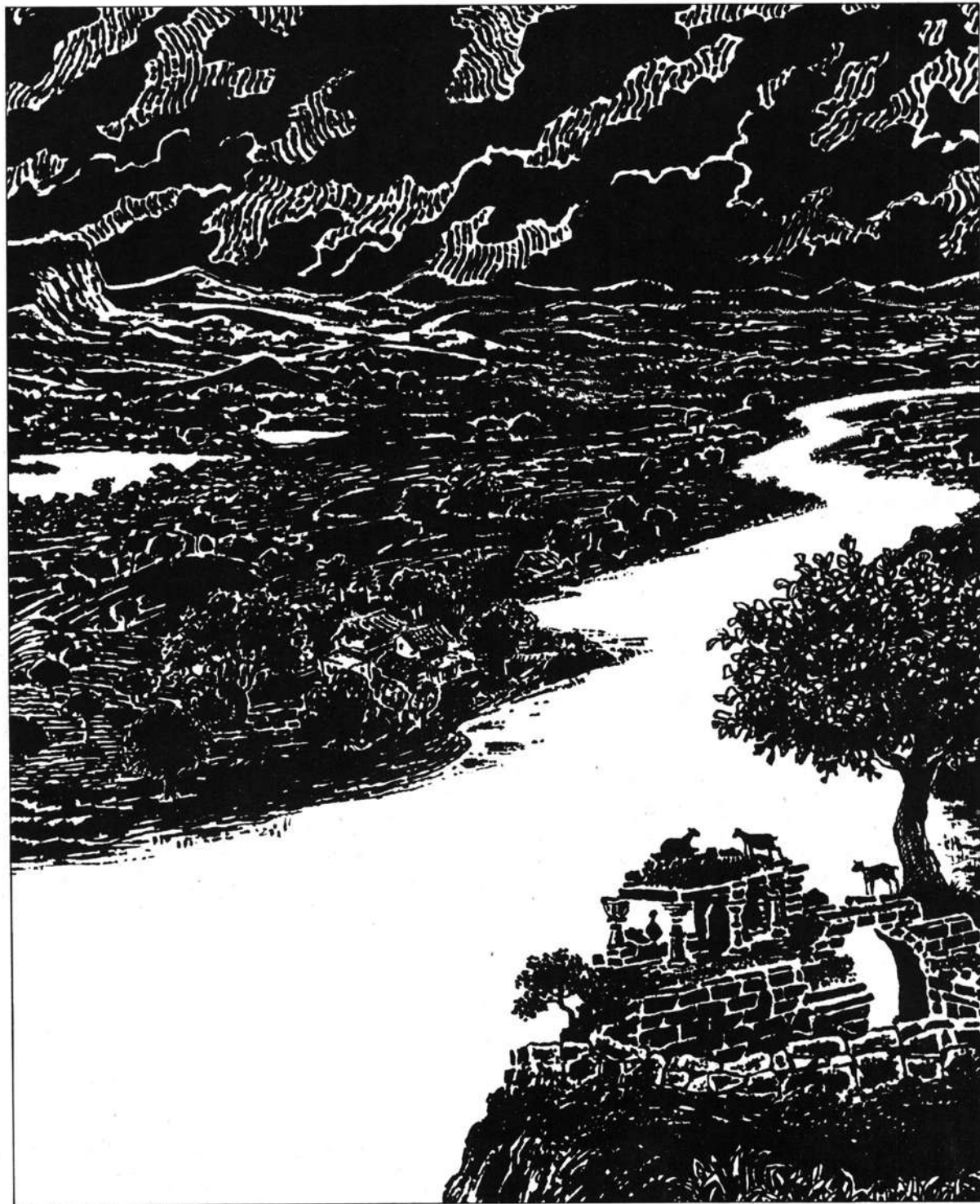
With no money or possessions



The rest of my family still lives there. But after I married, my husband found work in the city, and I left with him....



My life is like a river, mother
And on it I float away to the big city
I hear the sirens of the factory, father
Calling, beckoning... And leave your world
far behind...



Part II : THE RIVER

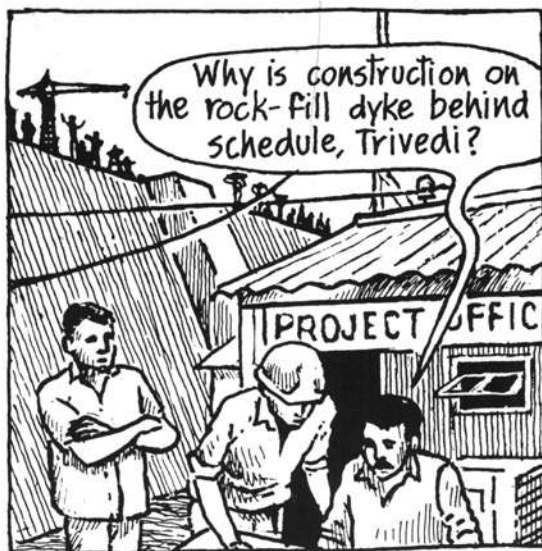
THE MOUNTAINS WERE CHANGING...

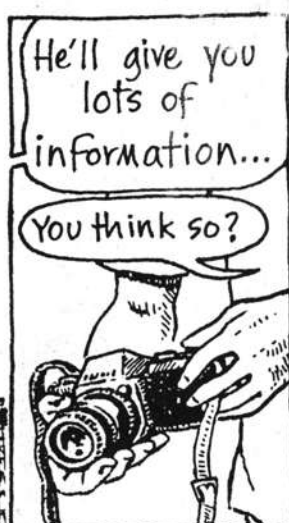
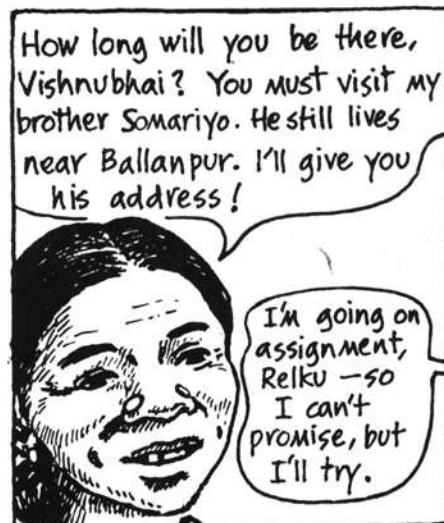
I came to the mountains. Tigers and bears were roaring. Ranikajal was crying, 'Now what do I do?' She called Ratukamai, 'Devur! devur! Our mountain is changing. What should we do?' Said Ratukamai, 'We should go to the maal and get the singer Malgu.'

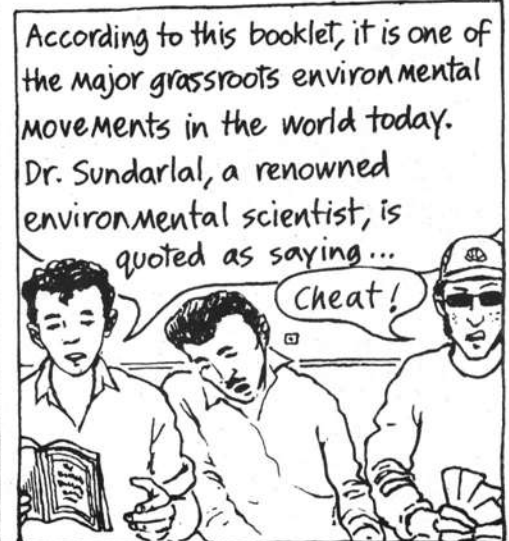
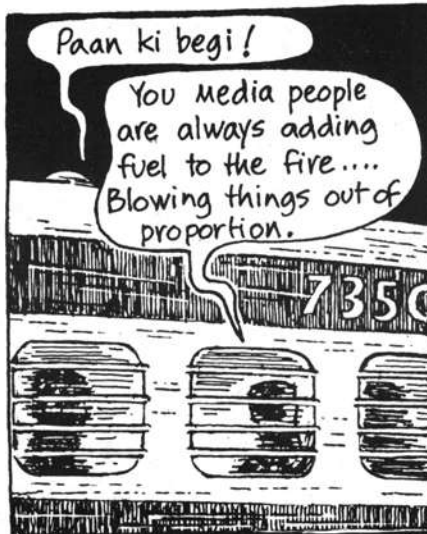
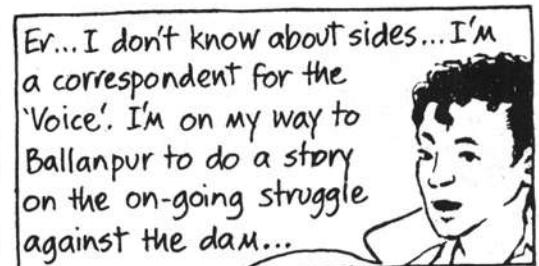
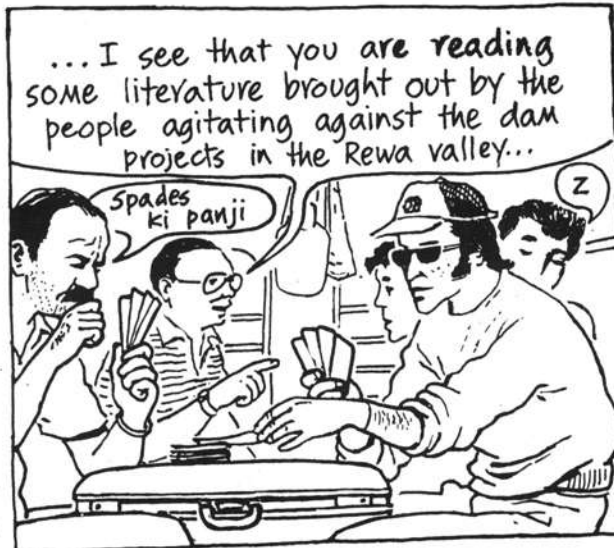
So who went? Ratukamai did. Went and caught the king's horse and took the path to Malapur. Reached and called, 'Dada! Dada!'

Malgu gayan sleeps for twelve years and snores for thirteen. He awoke with a start, 'Dada,' he said. 'What brings you here?'

Said Ratukamai, 'Our task is big. Our mountain is changing... Tigers and bears are roaring. So I have come to take you.' Replied Malgu gayan, 'Go now. I will come after four - five days.'







The tribals of the Rewa valley are fighting to preserve their ecosystem from destruction by our flawed development policies....



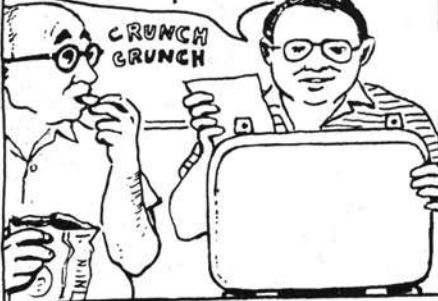
And here, Global Ecoforum, an international pressure group states: the movement in the Rewa valley has significance for the entire planet and its viewpoint should be heard..



I see their point, but one has to weigh the pros and cons of the situation. On the one hand ...



according to these official figures, about a hundred thousand people will lose their lands and homes due to submergence in the reservoir created by the dam....



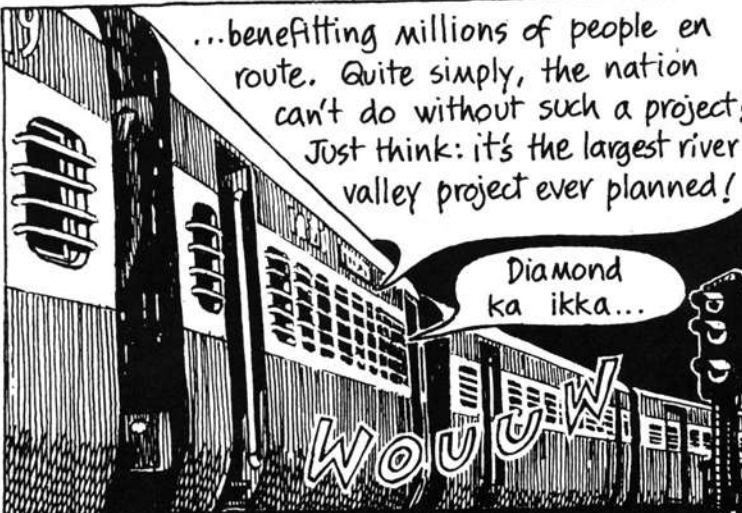
Around 375 square kilometres of forest and farmland will go under water... Even if you add another lakh of people to be displaced by the irrigation canal network, it's still nothing compared to the benefits the project will bring



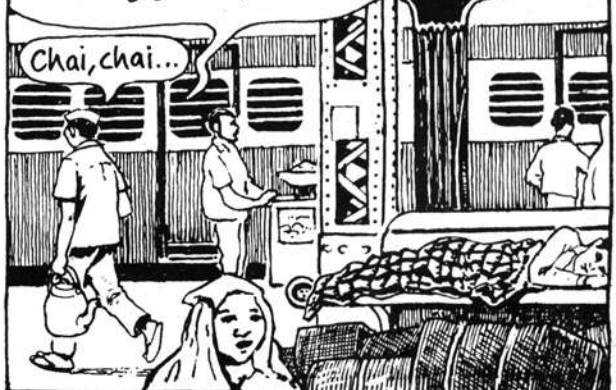
This dam will generate 1450 megawatts of power, the canals will carry irrigation and drinking water to drought-prone areas....



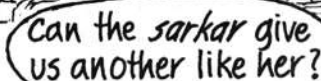
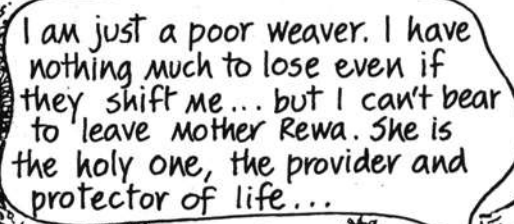
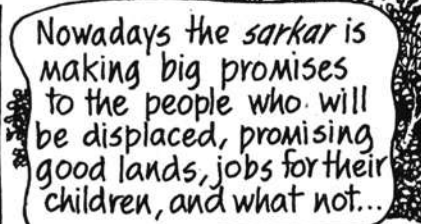
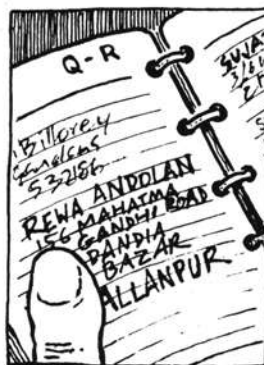
...benefitting millions of people en route. Quite simply, the nation can't do without such a project! Just think: it's the largest river valley project ever planned!

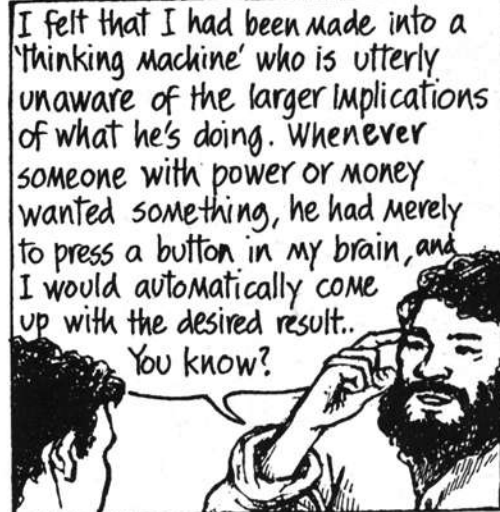
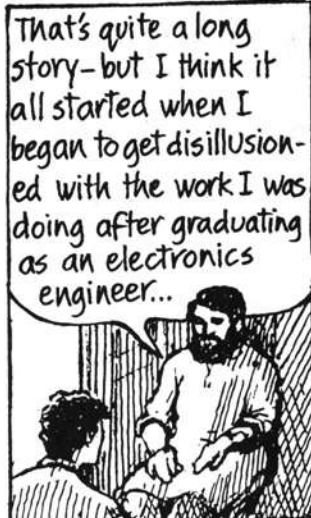
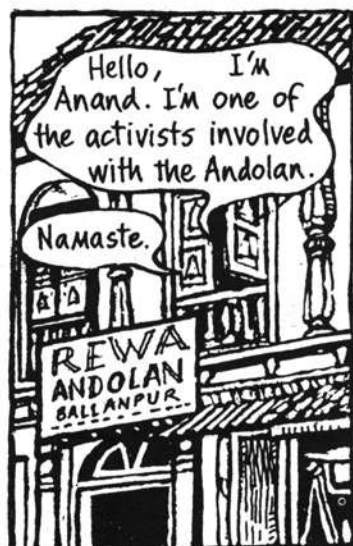


The government is taking international aid to the tune of \$600 million for it! It's so gigantic, it boggles the mind!







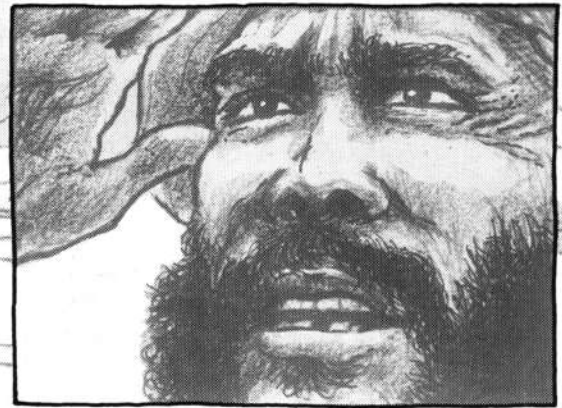


THE CHILDREN OF REWA

As soon as he read Malgu's letter, Relukabadi picked up his axe, chisel and a *matta* with water, and took to the stony path. Two daughters had Relu - Revli and Devli by name. When he set out for the big mountains, they followed. 'Daughters, you must not come! I go to the big mountains!' They did not listen. Kept going after him.



Relukabadi went to Vije mountain. Looked all over Vije mountain, but didn't find wood...



Dulye mountain, Andaryo mountain, Neelye mountain, Bhuryo mountain, Janjryo mountain, Haadyo maal, Dulye maal - all mountains he roamed, but did not find wood.



Hungry and thirsty, Relukabadi took the cloth off his head and spread it on the ground.

तारी
माडी सुखे!



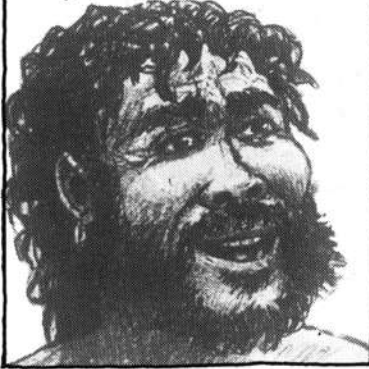
He started to cry.



But then he thought. Picked up some leaves of *palash* and started praying...



Prayed and sat. Looked up and saw a tall teak tree! Relukabadi laughed and smiled.



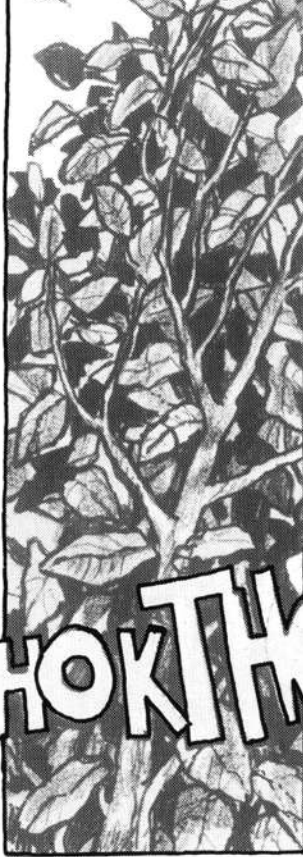
Picked up the axe,
And danced four times.



One blow of the axe to the tree, and a stream of blood gushed out. Hit another blow and..



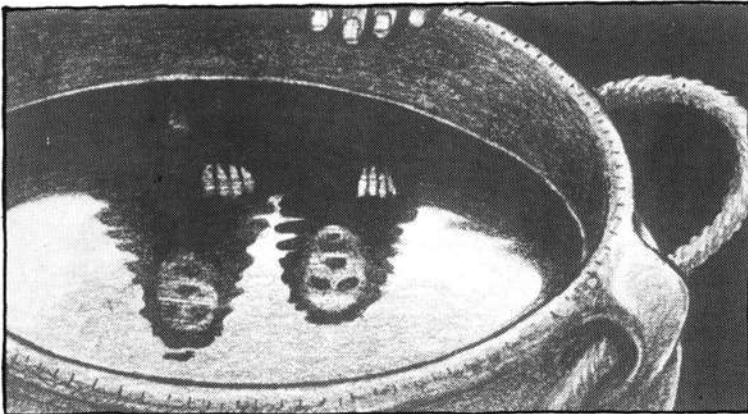
water flowed out. Hit another blow and milk poured out. A final blow, the tree turned black.



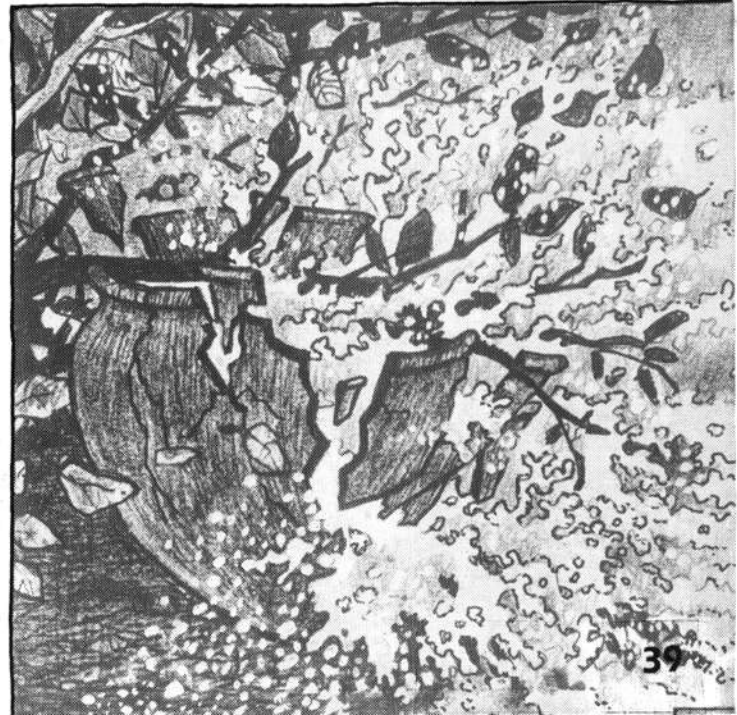
Relukabadi raised his head to see where the tree would fall.



THOK THOK THOK THOK THOK

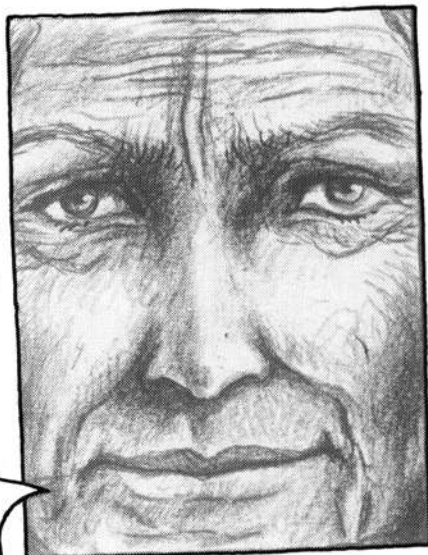


When Relukabadi looked up at the tree, his daughters went and hid behind his *matla*. The tree fell on it, and the *matla* broke...





All the water from the *matla* flowed out. Flowing with the water went Revli and Devli to Ambarkhant. Ambarkhant was barren. She started caring for the girls. She gave them names...



The first one, I name Ganga, Rewa. And the second one, Jamna, Vijali.



Meanwhile, Relukabadi started breaking branches from the tree. First he broke *ganjyo dhol*. After that, a *rangai*, then *heermangli*, then *raivajo*, *phoolvajo*, *duiki*, *tutdio* and *pipario* - all instruments he broke off. 'Now I shall give the *rangai* to Malgu gayan,' said he.

The rally today is taking place at Manigam, the first village that is scheduled for submergence...



The people of Manigam are going to pledge never to let anyone force them off their lands and homes. You'll also have a chance to talk to people....



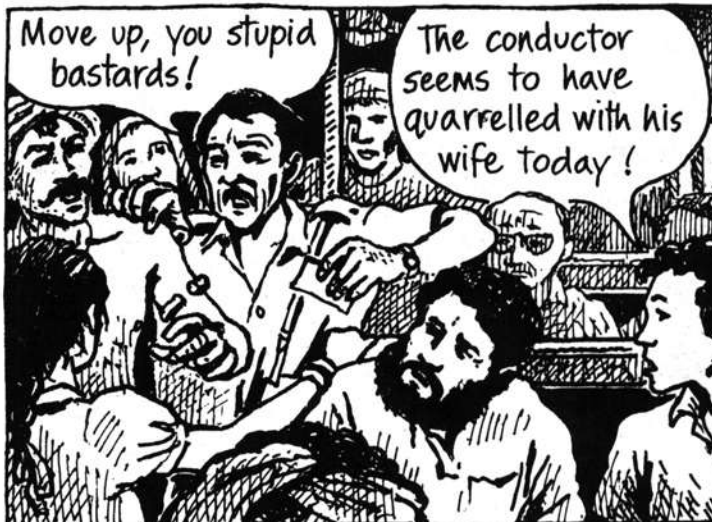
and get some first-hand accounts of their struggle. You'll get to visit the site of the dam, as well.



Look, how peaceful Rewa looks this morning!



Move up, you stupid bastards!



The conductor seems to have quarrelled with his wife today!

Oh no! That's the usual manner of the bazaris towards the adivasi!

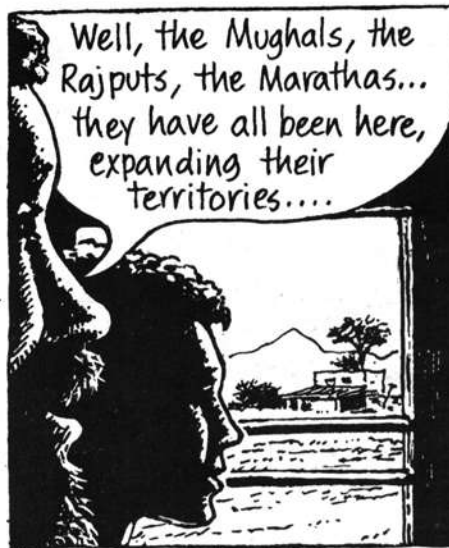


Right from the time the first outsiders started encroaching on tribal land, they have regarded the adivasi with a mixture of fear and contempt.



Really? Who were the first outsiders to come here?

Well, the Mughals, the Rajputs, the Marathas... they have all been here, expanding their territories....



Over the years, they managed to drive the adivasis into the hilly and forested tracts, and settled themselves on the more fertile valleys and plains... I suppose it's similar to what white settlers did in the Americas and Australia...



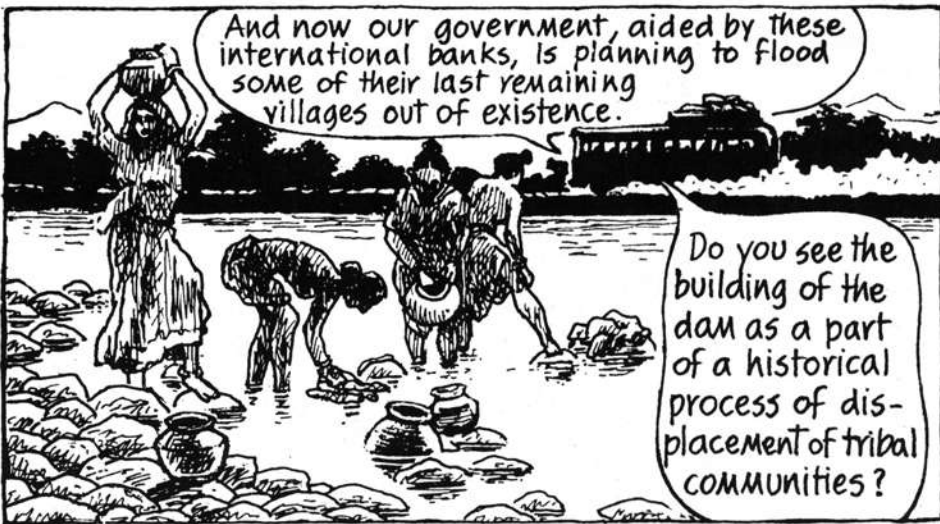
And when the British came?



The same process continued, but the significant thing that the British administration did was to introduce the concept of 'reserved forests'. That created the justification for taking over the forests of the tribals as well...



And now our government, aided by these international banks, is planning to flood some of their last remaining villages out of existence.

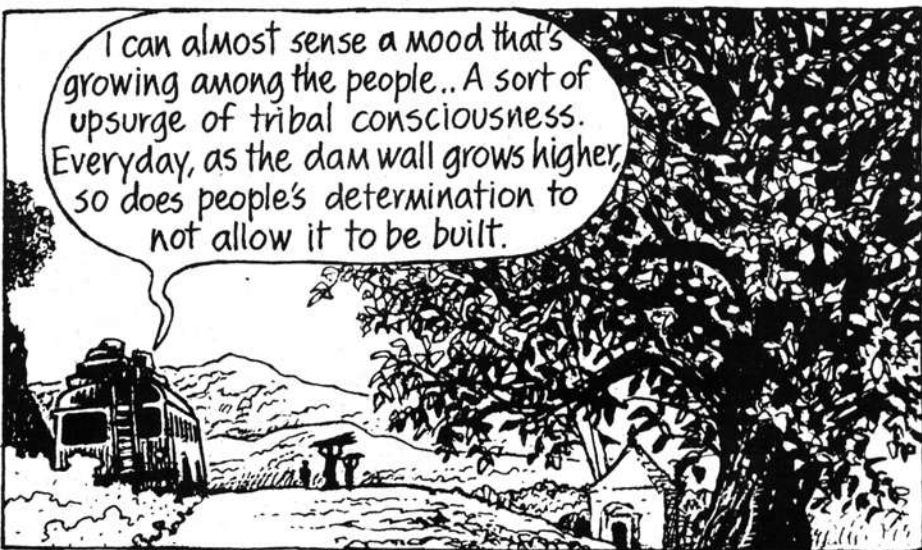


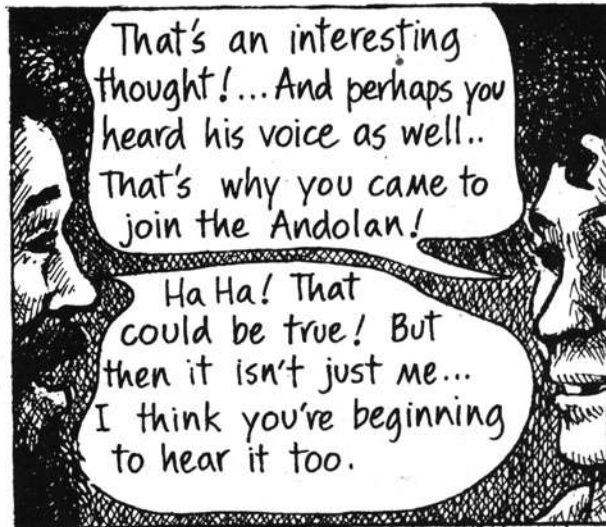
Do you see the building of the dam as a part of a historical process of displacement of tribal communities?

Definitely! But it's not as if the adivasis have not resisted all this. Legends of folk heroes who fought to retain their independence abound. Today, the struggle against the dam expresses that spirit of resistance...



I can almost sense a mood that's growing among the people.. A sort of upsurge of tribal consciousness. Everyday, as the dam wall grows higher, so does people's determination to not allow it to be built.





We resolve together, today, that we, who consider ourselves the children and the guardians of Mother Rewa, shall never allow the forces of greed and self-interest to wrongfully exploit her wealth...



... and plunder this land and this water that we hold cupped in our hands. We pledge to protect these for our future generations...



We are prepared to face them with the courage of peace and non-violence.



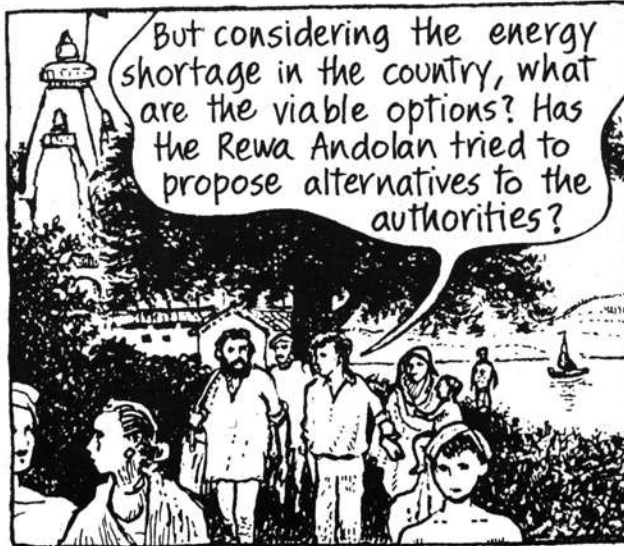
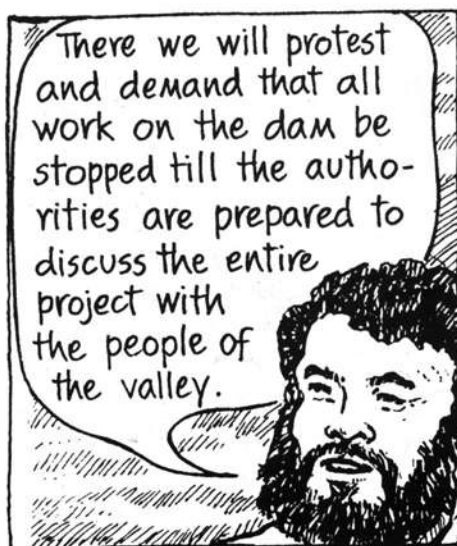
This is fantastic! I hope these pictures come out well.



.. we oppose all those who, in the name of development, commit crimes against humanity by tearing apart this earth for their own short-term gains...



Come on, we're holding a public meeting behind the temple. After that, we set off on a long march to the dam site.



Friends, we have gathered here today, not just to stop the building of a dam, but to assert the need in our country and the world for an alternative development model.

Today, our planet is seriously endangered, yet development continues to be based on an economic system which regards all forms of human and natural resources as goods which can be...

...bought and sold by anyone who can pay the price. Such a system is based on a way of thinking which disregards life and nature, and has little respect for it.

... It seeks to continually transfer natural resources from the poor to the rich, thus widening the gap between them, instead of narrowing it down.

We have rejected this way of thinking. Long ago, Mahatma Gandhi said, 'This earth has enough for everyone's needs, but not enough for anyone's greed.'

For our society to be ecologically sustainable, we must ensure an equal and fair share of resources for everybody.

Today's planners have taken us so far down the path of destructive development, that talking about alternatives may seem futile to some — and yet, that is precisely why we have all come together....

.... Because we want to express and share our confidence in our own knowledge and experience, and in our ability to live wisely with nature's gifts. I believe that a message of hope for the future is emerging....



Vishnubhai, you have come from far away to hear about our problems. What did you think of today's meeting?

It was really interesting! But tell me, what are the kind of alternatives you see to the way things are now?

An alternative way is one that does not benefit one person at the cost of another. In which people are consulted and their ideas respected. We are not so foolish as the *sarkar* thinks. Our knowledge is based on real life experience. If they had talked to us first, they might never have thought of this monstrous dam.

Yes, because then they would have realized how beautifully our own methods of irrigation used to work. We went to some villages of Gujra district with Anandbhai last year, where all the expertise of the engineer *babus* had been used to expand the old system of tanks and waterways - by checkdams, lift irrigation, windmills, and so many things!

Then all the money they are wasting here could have been spent on schools, medicines for our children..

... and tree planting, water harvesting, and other technologies which would regenerate the environment instead of destroying it.

That would truly have been development, because it would have meant a flow of resources and knowledge back to the people from whom it has always been taken away.

But the reason why things will never happen this way is because then no contractor would stand to make huge profits, no corrupt politician would manage to line his pockets!

Exactly! Anyhow, I'm going to get some sleep now. The march to the dam site will start very early!





Shrine of the sacred turtle of the spring where Malgu sang the song of Kujum Chantu.

Ambarkhant
the mother
monument marking the spot where Khajya Bhil, the rebel tribal chief, was murdered in his sleep by Rajput rulers of the area.

I am Malgu gayan. God give me wisdom. On my lap I have the rangai, given to me by Relukabadi, the woodcutter. I shall sing to you the song of Rewa, the river of stories, so listen well. When the rangai started to play, its music went all over the world. The tigers and bears turned back their ears in alarm. Rewa and Vijali started dancing and set off in different directions to meet Duda Hamad, the sea.

Hello, I'm from TV news. Can you tell our viewers why you are marching to the damsite?

Because our minds are made up. If the sarkar won't stop this dam, they'll have to do it on our dead bodies!

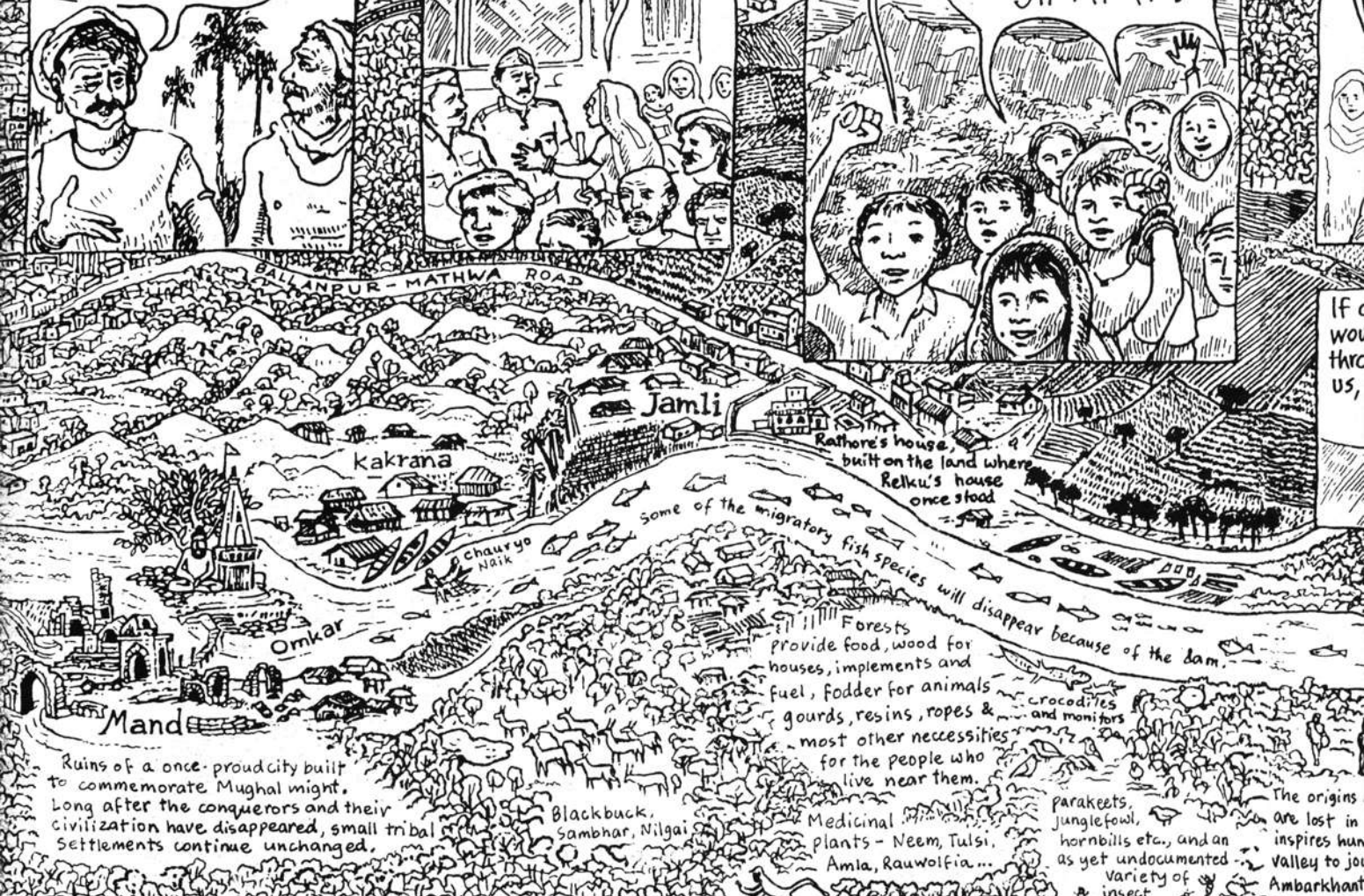
Rewa came to Rajghat. Being very pious, she gave it a name... and she called it Rajghat. From there she cascaded to Kalghat.

Why all this fuss? Do you think a handful of city people can stop Mother Rewa from flowing to meet the sea, her husband?

Look at you! You are a child of Rewa, just like us. Yet you are prepared to hurt your brothers and sisters for the sake of your POLICE NAUKRI!

देवा घाटी कुनीन से?

आमरी से!
आमरी से!



Ruins of a once-proud city built to commemorate Mughal might. Long after the conquerors and their civilization have disappeared, small tribal settlements continue unchanged.

Blackbuck, Sambhar, Nilgai

Forests provide food, wood for houses, implements and fuel, fodder for animals, gourds, resins, ropes & most other necessities for the people who live near them.

Medicinal plants - Neem, Tulsi, Amla, Rauwolfia...

parakeets, junglefowl, hornbills etc., and as yet undocumented variety of insect species.

The origins are lost in inspires hun valley to join Ambarkhan sea. The pa things, a wa interdepend who in habi

After giving it a name, she came to Peepalghat, and from there she went to Omkar Maharaj, who blessed her and bestowed on her the life-giving gifts. From there, she went forth cascading to Kakrana, Jamli, Bhitada ... each of these places she named.

Mixed Deciduous Forest



At Kak Said h hungry his fish lot of and e ... Mac Ma

Do you come all the way from Man to join in this protest?

Yes, because this dam represents what our entire human society has become - oppressive - foisted on us without our consent...



Only these bankers and ministers get off their Motors and walk through our forests and villages without being deeply ashamed of what they've done!



Manigam

Where the people of Rewa valley pledged never to desert their lands and waters.

the 'Rewa parikrama' time, but even today it is a tradition of people of the Rewa valley on foot from her source at the point where she meets the Kishna. She has been, apart from other things, to experience firsthand the natural beauty of the animals, forests and humans in its life-sustaining valley.

...ana, she met Chauryo Naik. 'Mother! Mother! I am very hungry. Give me something'. And he took a long rod and sat. 'My son, I have a snake in my belly. Kill them'. Finally, she reached Manigam. It was green and beautiful. Kesho was there a temple for her...

mountains of Vindhya

Rewa



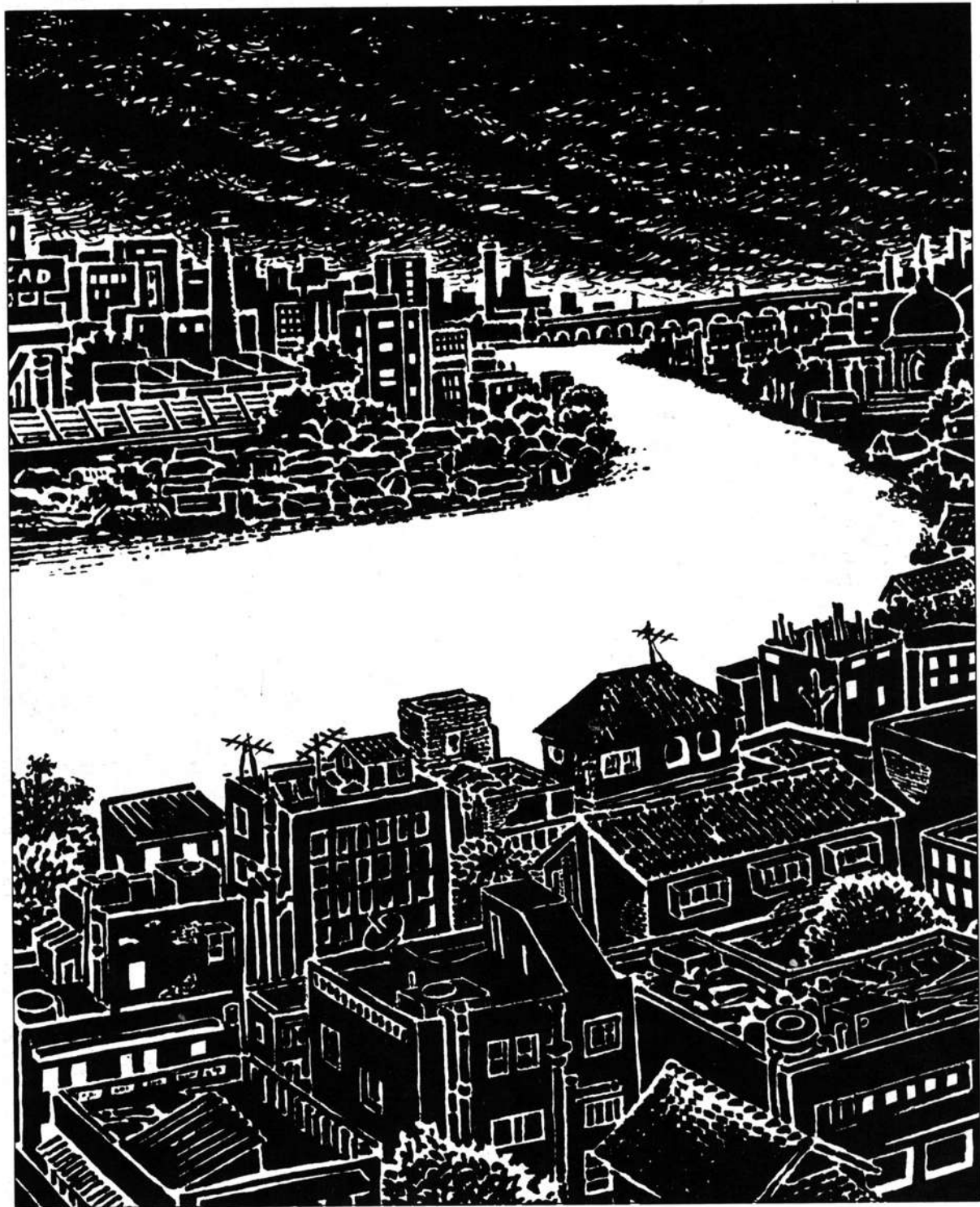
a map of stories told and as yet untold

What started as a trickle, has become a stream. What was a single stream, has been joined by myriad streams! What was once a rushing current, has become a broad river! And I dreamt what is today a river will tomorrow join the vast sea!

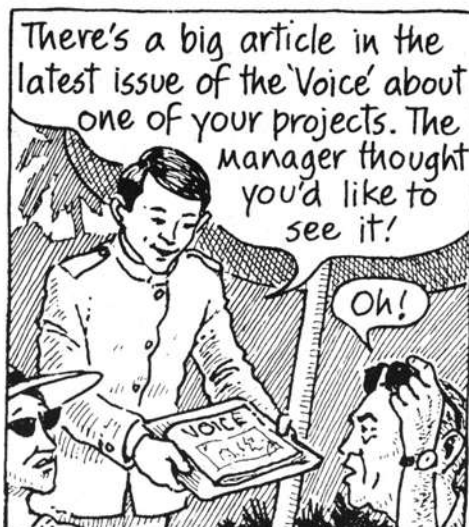
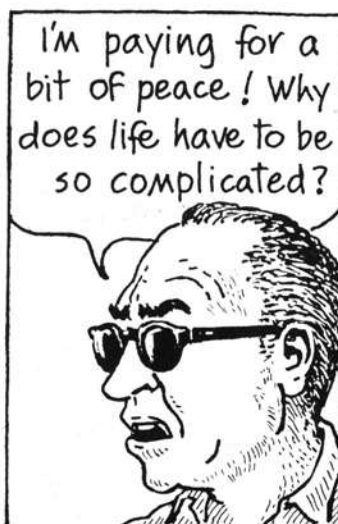
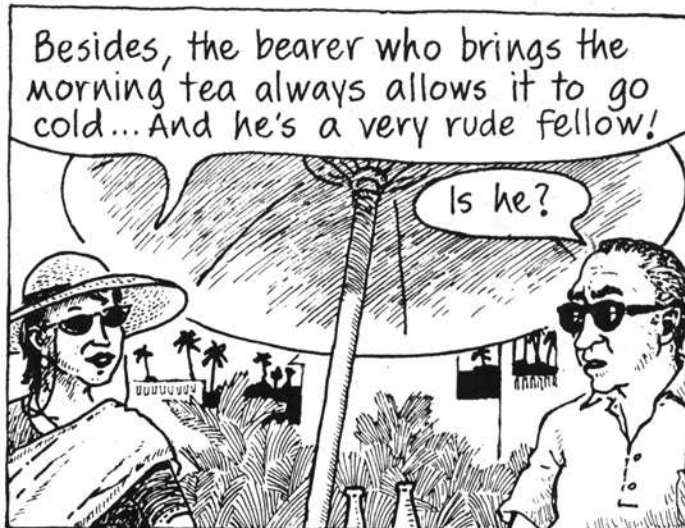
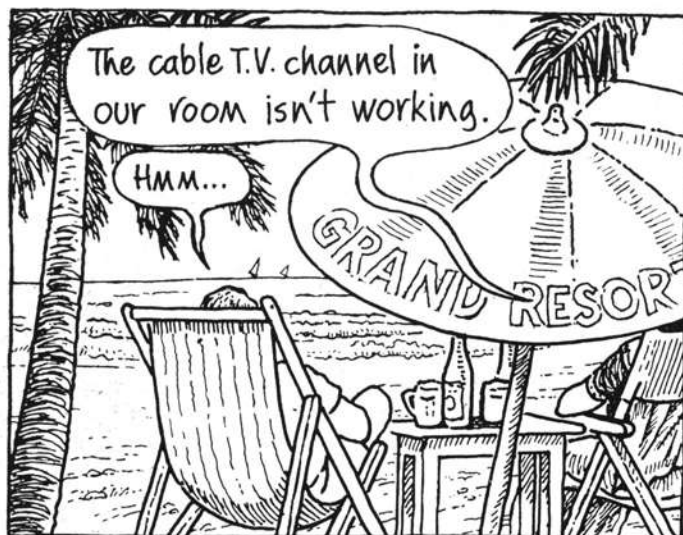


Rewa Sagar dam under construction

main canal



Part III : THE SEA



REWASAGAR DAM

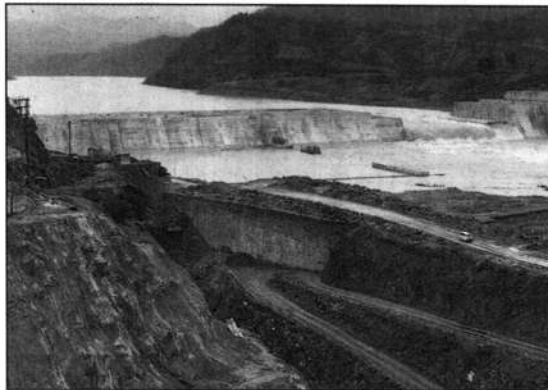
Monument Of Progress Or Wall Of Despair?

Protests against the building of the controversial Rewasagar Dam focus world attention on destructive 'development' projects

WITH every passing day, as the walls of the Rewasagar dam near Manigam village inch upwards, so does the determination of the nearly 100,000 *adivasis* and activists who have resolved to halt the project. For five long years, the poor villagers of Rewa Valley have fought an unequal battle for survival against some of the world's largest and most powerful governments, financiers and corporations. One visit to the valley is sufficient to convince even an unsympathetic observer of the Rewa Andolan's integrity and commitment to its cause.

But what has made these supposedly 'uneducated' and 'marginalised' communities of tribals, farmers and artisans so unequivocal in their opposition to a development project undertaken in the 'national interest'? What gives these simple people the conviction to take on encounters with *latbi*- and *gun*-wielding police, detention in jailhouses, frequent and long-drawn courtroom appearances and even

One of the families destined to be displaced.



The Rewasagar Dam under construction.

harassment by hired goons and musclemen?

To seek an answer to these questions, I travelled to the villages along the river and met farmers, tribals, activists, women and even children, who had a lot to say. Without exception they were happy that I had come from far away — from another world, so to say — to listen to their voices and hopefully put them down in black and white, for the world to understand.

Khursheo, a tribal peasant from Umargaon, spoke of the disastrous effect the dam would have on his entire com-

"The government says they will resettle us. But our community will be broken up. Our music, our festivals, our gatherings, will all come to an end. Will there be any point in living after that?"

KHURSHEO, Umargaon

munity. "Our village will be submerged for ever," he said. "The government says they will resettle us. But our community will be broken up. For countless generations, uncles, cousins, clan relations have lived close to each other. Even when our girls are married into other villages and clans, they are always able to journey on foot or by bullock cart back to their parents whenever they want to. When they shift us out to different places, we will all be cut off from each other. Our ancestors and spirits, who reside in the forests and hills, will be abandoned. Our music, our festivals, our gatherings, will all come to an end. Will there be any point in continuing to live after that?"

Danu Naik, from the fishing community of Bhitada, sat by the river's edge one evening, recounting his childhood spent in growing up on the banks of the Rewa. "Even in the *Gayana* sung by Malgu *gayan*, there is mentioned this village where my ancestor, Chauryo Naik was given the permission to kill fish by Mother Rewa herself. When I was young and not yet able to steer my boat, I used to sit on that overhanging rock over there and pretend to be Chauryo Naik asking Mother Rewa for food, to fill my belly, and Mother would answer: 'Take the fish from me and eat'. Then I'd go catching small *bilsa* fish near the rocks with a bowl covered with a piece of cloth which had a hole. I'd keep some insects inside the bowl. The fish would enter through the hole and get trapped. The *bilsa* always come up from the sea in the rainy season to spawn over here. But the dam will block their route and the fish won't be able to swim up."

Wizened with age, Buribai was passionate in her denouncement: "These *bazaarias* come here only to create trouble — to beat up our men and molest us women. Now the *sarkar* expects us to leave our villages to go and live amongst these same people? I prefer to drown!"

The opposition to the dam is not



Protests and demonstrations are marked by a positive sense of affirmation of tribal identity.

confined only to the people who will be displaced. The movement has drawn many people from different backgrounds towards it. Anand, an ex-electronics engineer, has been involved full-time with the movement for over two years. He argues that even if the human dimensions of the problem were to be ignored, the dam is a non-viable proposition.

THOSE who plan these projects take into account only the finite, known variables at stake. When they calculate the working lifespan of a dam, they don't take into account, for example, the effects of the deforestation that has been taking place upstream of the dam. This will cause massive soil erosion along the river banks, which in turn will lead to the reservoir getting silted up and unusable a lot earlier than predicted. The underground seepage from this massive reservoir will cause land around it to get waterlogged causing salinity and reducing what is now fertile agricultural land to a wasteland. "They never calculate indirect damages such as these into their so-called cost-benefit analyses," says Anand, "because if they did, the project would be shown to be economically non-viable."

Ecologists also point out that

forests. "Do we have a right to destroy something whose importance we don't even understand?" they ask.

Rahul Ram of the Environment Research Group quoted from some of the studies his group has conducted at other dams. "At Bikra Dam — one of India's largest — we found that the artificial creation of large stagnant water bodies can create a variety of health problems for people around. The incidence of malaria and other water-borne diseases has gone up sharply in the years since the dam was constructed. In fact the government has recently undertaken a massive malaria eradication programme in the area costing lakhs of rupees.

"They've sprayed poisonous pesticides and chemicals on the lake. Now we'll have to wait and see how that is going to affect the health of people," he adds sarcastically.

Maya Phule has been associated with

some of the forests slated for submergence are rich ecosystems which play a vital role in preserving climatic balances, underground water caches and other critical ecological systems. No comprehensive studies yet exist of the myriad species of flora and fauna in these

the movement from its earliest days. At a public meeting at Manigam, she spoke of the need to conceive of a fresh attitude towards development. "Such mega-projects are justified by planners who quote figures of what our energy requirements in the year so-and-so will be," she says, "or what kind of food production we will need, without considering the distribution of these resources.

"About 70 per cent of our population consumes only 30 per cent of our resources. So the remaining 70 per cent is consumed by the wealthy 30 per cent.

"The history of 'progress' in our country has proven beyond doubt that the poor at best remain poor. Usually they get poorer. So our battle is not only against this dam. It is against the entire idea of development as we experience it today"

MAYA PHULE,
Anti-dam activist

Should we sacrifice the future of our planet, just so that their unsustainable lifestyles can continue? Because the history of 'progress' in our country has proven beyond doubt that the poor at best remain poor. Usually they get poorer. So our battle is not only against this dam. It is against the entire idea of development as we experience it today. We must have an alternative model which genuinely guarantees development — for those who need it most."

Phule's ideas are not entirely new, but what is interesting about the Andolan critique is its clear perception of the inseparability of social justice and ecological sustainability. Back in the teeming metropolis, surrounded by the sights and sounds of progress, one cannot help but marvel at the people of Rewa Valley, and the inescapable truth that lies behind their convictions. ●

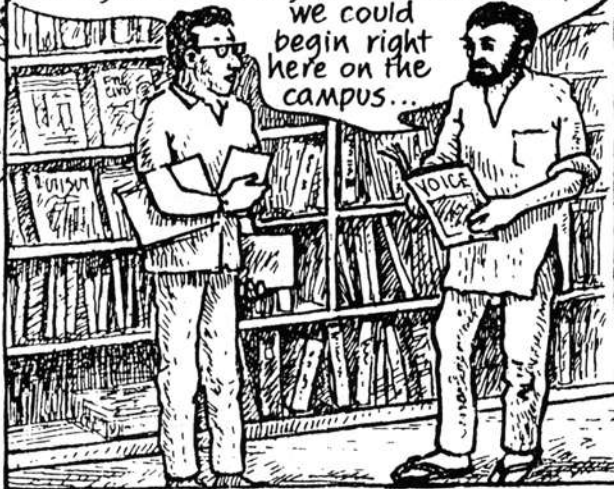


A shrine to the sacred turtles of Rewa.

But if they stop development projects, how are we to progress? Obviously, a few people have to suffer for the good of the majority... Surely these environmentalists don't expect us to go back to the middle ages, do they? What's the point of writing such negative articles?

Do you think these environmentalists really care about tribals? They're in it to make a name for themselves. Anyway, why ask questions that have no answer? Let's go to the Plaza for a beer!

Some of us have been thinking about forming a support group here to campaign for the Rewa Andolan and other grassroots organizations... Perhaps we could begin right here on the campus...



Maybe we are coming full circle finally! All these centuries, we've been trying to teach all these 'backward' people what civilization is all about. Now we have to admit that it is THEY who might have the answers!



Here's the letter I'm the editor - Dear Sir, article on the Rewa was well written. honest and informed issues such as these. be more public parti the decision-making which affect not generation, but future as well!



What nonsense these magazines print nowadays! A handful of tribals start making a noise somewhere, and they have a two-page article on it! Basically, these so-called poor people want everything without working for it!... And when they don't get it, they want to stop others from having it.



Hello, Moorthy? Did you read the article in the 'Voice'? ... Yes, I know... It's very bad publicity for us. This sort of thing could affect our other dam-construction contracts as well! Please arrange to issue a press release to counter the 'Voice' article...



Look, that's Dhediya! from my village, Vishnubh

I think we, the tion, interest are go change there's ally ... but to ask



If our own government is ready to violate our human rights, then who do we turn to? Our Constitution guarantees the right of every citizen to live his life with dignity in the place and in the manner of his choice!

If we'd actually followed Gandhiji's ideals, all these problems would not have come up today... But we chose to ape the West and abandoned our own culture.



But, Dadu, we would have been living in a very boring world... I mean, without any discos or movies, or hamburgers, or anything!



writing to your Sagar dam We need an debate on Let there cipation In processes only our ones

Read that 'Voice' article I was showing you? Yes... why must these people meddle in things they don't understand?



As though they know better than scientists and engineers!

old He's ai!



Today, 'activist' has come to mean the same thing as 'terrorist'! These people are funded by foreign countries who don't want our nation to become powerful. They are told by their foreign masters to go to backward areas and spread wrong ideas in the minds of people! We should denounce them as anti-nationals!



BHARATIYA AN RALLY

Raj, you must see this article by Indu's son - Vishnu. He seems to have become quite an idealistic young fellow - ha ha!



until and unless younger genera- take a more active in the way things ing, nothing can Everyone knows something drastic- wrong somewhere. nobody wants questions.

Oh yes... I read something very interesting the other day.. India is one of the wettest countries in the world. It receives more average rainfall than some of America's biggest food-producing regions! Yet we are made to believe that this is a drought-prone country, incapable of meeting its own food requirements!

It's like that Bob Marley song... 'This is the rat race - in the abundance of water, the fool is thirsty - rat race, rat race - oh, it's a disgrace to see the human race in a rat race!'



